Letsema in partnership with Skift Advisory, for Wesgro

Unlocking Tourism Growth

A Strategy for the Western Cape to 2035

Final Research Report

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Foreword

[Foreword by the Chief Executive Officer of Wesgro, one page. To be drafted by Wesgro or ghost-written by Letsema for sign-off, SLA Annexure B clause 1.1.14.5.]

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Abbreviations

Abbreviation	Meaning
ACSA	Airports Company South Africa
CAGR	Compound annual growth rate
CTAA	Cape Town Air Access
CTIA	Cape Town International Airport
CTICC	Cape Town International Convention Centre
CTT	Cape Town Tourism
DEDAT	Department of Economic Development and Tourism, Western Cape Government
DMO	Destination marketing organisation
FTE	Full-time equivalent
FY	Financial year (April to March)
G4J	Growth for Jobs Strategy, Western Cape Government, 2023
GCC	Gulf Cooperation Council
GDPR	Gross domestic product by region
GVA	Gross value added
ICCA	International Congress and Convention Association
LTO	Local tourism organisation
M&E	Monitoring and evaluation
Mero	Municipal Economic Review and Outlook
MICE	Meetings, incentives, conferences and exhibitions
OAG	Official Airline Guide (schedules and capacity data)
OSM	OpenStreetMap
OTA	Online travel agency
Pero	Provincial Economic Review and Outlook
RACI	Responsible, accountable, consulted, informed
SAT	South African Tourism
SLA	Service level agreement
SMME	Small, medium and micro enterprise
Stats SA	Statistics South Africa
TSA	Tourism Satellite Account
UIA	Union of International Associations
VFR	Visiting friends and relatives
WTTC	World Travel and Tourism Council

Executive summary

This file is a work-in-progress build of the final report, packaged on 3 November 2026 for review of the structure, the build and the first drafted section.

What this build contains and what it does not

Contains. The front matter (cover, document control, foreword placeholder, contents, lists of figures and tables, abbreviations) and section 1.2, The Western Cape tourism system today, drafted from the verified evidence extracts with three figures and three tables. Section 1.2 has not yet passed its adversarial review; a reviewer is checking every figure against the source pages.

Does not yet contain. Sections 1.1, 1.3, 1.4 and 1.5 (drafting in progress); Chapter 2 (six analysis summaries, next); Chapter 3 (20 focus-area entries, after Chapter 2); Chapters 4 and 5; the appendices; the executive summary, which is written last from the Chapter 3 toplines.

Evidence base behind it. Twelve deliverables and memos read in full and adversarially verified, figure by figure; a reconciliation log of 55 discrepancies between the structure document, the brief and the deliverables (discrepancies.md); a reconstruction of the hypothesis tree with dispositions (evidence/tree.md); fact sheets for five of the six themes, with the sixth and the audits in progress.

Conventions already in force. Every figure carries a source and page in the form (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p21); page numbers are PDF page indices because the decks print none; square brackets mark open items; every page carries the draft marking; figures are redrawn from the extracted data rather than pasted.

Context

1.1 Mandate and objective

Wesgro commissioned a strategy to "double international tourist arrivals to the Western Cape by 2035"; the evidence has reframed that ambition as growth to 2.5 million arrivals, set by supply rather than demand.

Wesgro's mandate

Wesgro's mandate frames this strategy. The agency promotes tourism, trade and investment for Cape Town and the Western Cape, and the tourism goal sits inside that wider economic brief. Its mission is to work "together with partners, drive inclusive and sustainable economic growth, strengthen competitiveness, and create jobs in Cape Town and the Western Cape" (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p5).

Its vision is to "be a leading regional tourism, trade and investment promotion agency" (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p5). Two points in the mission matter for what follows: growth is a means to jobs, and Wesgro acts through partners rather than holding the levers itself.

Wesgro's strategy runs to eight statements, quoted here as printed (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p5):

- "Ensure that Cape Town and the Western Cape is top of mind as a leading business and tourism destination with premium products and services."
- "Prioritise new investment into identified export priority areas"
- "Increase re-investment and expansion from existing WC businesses"
- "Unlock access to new markets and new buyers - China, ASEAN, India, Brazil & Middle East, while maintaining a continued focus on established markets"
- "Enhance and replicate catalytic delivery models to deliver economic impact with partners in key areas"
- "Track and address systemic challenges influencing economic competitiveness."
- "Provide economic data, insights & analytics for the Western Cape."
- "Digitally transform across all our mandates to place clients at the centre of how we deliver services, enable staff and to empower stakeholders."

Four of the eight bear directly on this study. The first sets the destination proposition and the fourth names the new buyer markets while holding the established ones. The sixth commits Wesgro to act on systemic constraints to competitiveness and the seventh makes it the province's source of economic data.

The study objective and the original ambitions

The study objective was set in November 2025. It reads in full: "To develop an evidence-based tourism strategy that will double international tourist arrivals to the Western Cape by 2035, through a holistic approach that drives demand, strengthens supply and enables inclusive, sustainable and geographically dispersed growth aligned with WESGRO's strategic priorities" (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p4). That sentence fixes the three pillars the report keeps throughout: demand, supply and enablement.

Four headline ambitions sat under the objective: 2.8 million international visitors, 300,000 tourism-linked jobs, 10,000 SMMEs onboarded and twice the airlift and cruise volumes (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p4). None carried a base year, a baseline value or a definition; the only year on the slide is 2035. A month later the Current State Diagnostic restated the ambition as 5.7 million arrivals and R54.7 billion in tourism spend by 2035, again without a base (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p5).

The two statements do not reconcile with each other or with the measured baseline. Cape Town International recorded 1.44 million international passenger arrivals in FY24/25 (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p25). Twice that is 2.88 million, close to the 2.8 million ambition and nowhere near 5.7 million, and neither ambition names the series it counts.

The demand model tested the ambition and reframed it. From a 2025 base of 1,498,829 international arrivals, the base case reaches 2,175,778 by 2035 and the accelerated case 2,516,282, with a conservative floor of 1,822,634 (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p19). The accelerated case is what this strategy calls growth to 2.5 million, and it is the goal the report carries.

The reframing rests on what the model says about access: the base case assumes Wesgro's effort at 2025 intensity, selective frequency gains on existing routes and continued hub expansion (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p18). The accelerated case adds confirmed direct routes to India and China, above-baseline activation and more hub capacity into Cape Town (p18). The model's own footnote is blunt: without confirmed routes, volume reverts to base (p19).

Even the base case runs into a ceiling. Current air access caps inbound capacity at 1.8 million seats, and the base case first passes that line at the 2030 plotted year, at 1,802,929 arrivals (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p20). Growth to 2.5 million is therefore a supply programme before it is a marketing programme, and every chapter of this report returns to that point.

The reframing was tabled with Wesgro at the summary-of-findings session of 14 October 2026 [Summary of Findings, 14 Oct 2026, page to be confirmed against the final deck]. The table below sets each original ambition against the baseline in hand and the form in which the strategy now carries it.

Table 1.1. The study reframed the arrivals ambition on evidence and carried the other three ambitions forward with their baselines still to be fixed.

Ambition (November 2025)	Baseline in hand	How the strategy carries it
2.8 million international visitors by 2035	1.44m international passenger arrivals at Cape Town International, FY24/25 (Diagnostic p25); model base 1,498,829 in 2025 (Market Assessment p19)	Growth to 2.5 million: accelerated case 2,516,282 and base case 2,175,778 by 2035 (Market Assessment p19). The Diagnostic's 5.7 million arrivals and R54.7 billion spend (p5) is recorded as superseded
300,000 tourism-linked jobs	No Western Cape tourism employment figure in any deliverable	Carried to Chapter 5 as a ratio-based projection, pending the labour analysis the strategy commissions under workforce and service skills (focus area 20, flagged)
10,000 SMMEs onboarded	No baseline or definition printed [Wesgro to confirm the baseline count and definition of SMMEs onboarded]	Carried as community inclusion, measured in visitor spend reaching priority communities rather than a count of firms; see 2.6 and Chapter 5
Twice the airlift and cruise volumes	Airlift: inbound capacity capped at 1.8 million seats (Market Assessment p20). Cruise: 79 vessels in the 2024/25 season (Diagnostic p37)	Airlift carried as the seats and routes needed to lift the 1.8 million ceiling (3.2.1). Cruise carried as calls and ports (3.2.1) [Cruise Cape Town to confirm the call target and its definition]

Source: Inception Report, Nov 2025, p4; Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p5, p25, p37; Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p19, p20.

Wesgro's outcome metrics

Wesgro measures itself against six strategic outcomes, each with one metric (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p6). The slide prints no period for any of them [Wesgro to confirm the period over which the six outcome metrics are measured]. The six are:

- A differentiated Cape Town and the Western Cape as a leading regional economy: 120 million audience reached to consider Cape Town and the Western Cape as a leading trade and tourism destination
- Increased foreign and domestic investment: R30 billion new investment with a focus on targeted areas and markets
- Growth in Western Cape exports of goods and services: R9.1 billion new export declarations for goods and services
- Growth in leisure tourism consideration in international and local markets: 800,000 to 1 million new international tourist arrivals
- Growth in business events hosted in the Western Cape: 161 business event bids secured with an estimated economic value of R4.5 billion
- A future-fit and trusted Wesgro: clean audit, satisfied clients and low culture entropy

Two of the six are tourism metrics, and the period decides how they compare with the growth case. The base case adds 676,949 arrivals between 2025 and 2035 and the accelerated case 1,017,453 (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p19), so 800,000 to 1 million new arrivals sits between the two paths over a ten-year horizon. Over a horizon to 2030 it sits well above the base case, which adds about 304,000 by then (1,802,929 against 1,498,829; p20).

The business-events metric ties to the green-season case. International association meetings in Cape Town rose from 33 in 2022 to 58 in 2024 and are "primarily hosted between May and November" (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p26). That window takes in five of the six green-season months, April to September (p25). Chapter 5 fixes the period for both metrics and sets them against the growth case on one basis.

Alignment with provincial strategy

The SLA requires this report to align with the Growth for Jobs Strategy and with Wesgro's five-year plan (SLA Annexure B, clause 1.1.14.2). The inception report carries the same instruction: recommendations are to align with both the G4J strategy and Wesgro's FY26 to FY30 plan (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p22). The report is the Final Research Report under clause 1.1.14. Chapter 5 answers the monitoring and evaluation clauses 1.1.4 and 1.1.10 [clause references to be checked against the signed SLA Annexure B, whose wording is not in hand].

The Growth for Jobs Strategy 2023, approved by Cabinet, was among the first documents Wesgro supplied to the study (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p34). It designates tourism a primary tradable sector for the province (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p5). Its arrivals target is 3 million international tourist arrivals by 2035 on the South African Tourism basis, built as 2 million in 2019 plus 1 million (Wesgro, presentation to the parliamentary committee, 1 Apr 2026; public source). [G4J 2023 document to be read and the 3 million target confirmed against it.]

The G4J figure and the study's figures count different things. Three million is provincial tourist arrivals as South African Tourism measures them; 1.44 million is passenger arrivals through one airport as ACSA counts them. On the SAT basis the province received about 1.5 million international tourist arrivals in 2025, an 11.1% increase (Hypertext, Apr 2026, reporting the Provincial Minister; public source). [Wesgro Research to confirm the 2025 SAT figure and the series behind it.] The strategy's 2.5 million therefore cannot be set against the 3 million without conversion.

Wesgro's FY26 to FY30 plan is the second alignment test. A Wesgro five-year strategy was supplied to the study (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p34), but no plan document is in hand. Alignment is therefore stated at the level the inception report gives it [Wesgro to supply the FY26 to FY30 plan and its tourism targets, so that the Chapter 5 baselines and the Chapter 4 phase gates can be mapped to the plan cycle]. Chapter 4 sets its first decision gate at the end of 2028, within the plan period and before the base case reaches the seat ceiling.

One set of arrivals bases

Eight arrivals figures circulate around this strategy and they count four different things. The table below fixes each one and states how the report uses it, so that no later chapter mixes an airport count with a provincial tourist count or an ambition with a projection. Cape Town International is where international visitors enter the province and disperse from, and the Diagnostic itself uses Cape Town air arrivals as the proxy for provincial performance (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p26, p41).

Table 1.2. The report uses airport passenger arrivals for baselines, the demand model for targets and South African Tourism's provincial count only to read across to the Growth for Jobs target.

Figure	What it counts	Year	Source	How this report uses it
1.44m	International passenger arrivals at Cape Town International (ACSA), fiscal year	FY24/25	Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p25	Recovery baseline (1.2) and the baseline year for the M&E framework (Chapter 5)
1.57m	Same series	FY25/26	Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p10	Latest actual; shown against the model, not substituted for its base
1,498,829	Demand model base; the series and year basis are not labelled in the deck	2025	Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p19	Base of the growth case; every 2035 figure in Chapters 3 to 5 is an increment on it
2,175,778 and 2,516,282	Model projections on the 2025 base: base case and accelerated case	2035	Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p19	The strategy's two paths; growth to 2.5 million is the rounded accelerated case
About 1.5m	International tourist arrivals to the Western Cape, South African Tourism basis	2025	Hypertext, Apr 2026, reporting the Provincial Minister; public source	Reference point for the G4J basis only; not a baseline or a target [Wesgro Research to confirm the figure and its series]
3 million	International tourist arrivals to the province, SAT basis, built as 2 million in 2019 plus 1 million	2035	Wesgro, presentation to the parliamentary committee, 1 Apr 2026 (public source), recording the G4J 2023 target	Alignment reference under clause 1.1.14.2; a different measure from the airport series
2.8m	"International visitors"; measure and base not stated	2035	Inception Report, Nov 2025, p4	Original ambition; quoted, not used

Figure	What it counts	Year	Source	How this report uses it
5.7 million and R54.7 billion	International arrivals and tourism spend; base not stated	2035	Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p5	The Diagnostic's statement of the ambition; superseded and quoted for the record

Source: Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p5, p25; Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p10, p19; Inception Report, Nov 2025, p4; Wesgro, presentation to the parliamentary committee, 1 Apr 2026 (public source); Hypertext, Apr 2026, reporting the Provincial Minister; public source.

Three rules follow. Airport passenger arrivals at Cape Town International, by fiscal year, are the baseline and tracking series, with FY24/25 at 1.44 million anchoring 1.2 and the Chapter 5 baseline year. The demand model's 2025 base and its 2035 points are the target series, and South African Tourism's provincial count is used once, to read across to the G4J target.

One caution closes the section: the FY25/26 actual of 1.57 million already sits above the model's 2025 base and below its 2028 base-case point of 1,673,855 (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p10, p20). The two series differ in measure and period, so the gap is not evidence that the model is cautious. The report quotes them side by side and never adds one to the other [model owner to confirm the series and year basis behind the 2025 base of 1,498,829].

1.2 The Western Cape tourism system today

The Western Cape's international tourism has recovered to a record, and the system that delivered the recovery runs through five source markets, six summer months and one metro.

Arrivals and recovery

International passenger arrivals at Cape Town International reached 1.44m in FY24/25, against 1.16m in FY19/20, the last pre-pandemic year (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p25). Arrivals passed the pre-pandemic peak of 1.19m, set in FY18/19, during FY23/24, when they reached 1.36m (p25). FY25/26 added a further step to 1.57m (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p11).

The fall and the climb were both steep. Arrivals dropped to 80,400 in FY20/21 and 378,500 in FY21/22, then returned to 1.07m in FY22/23 (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p25). Two-way international passengers reached 2.90m in FY24/25, 29% above FY17/18 (p35), and 3.3m in calendar 2025 inside a total of 11.1m, both up 7% on the year (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p22).

Cape Town's recovery also ran ahead of the national one, so the destination gained share as it recovered. In the first half of 2024 its air arrivals had recovered further against 2019 than South Africa's in eight of the ten largest markets (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p26). The USA stood at 162% and Australia at 172% of their 2019 level (p26).

Three arrivals measures

The 1.44m is ACSA's count of international passengers arriving at Cape Town International in the fiscal year. It is the series this report uses as its recovery baseline and its monitoring base year (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p25).

South African Tourism counts tourist arrivals to the province, which the Demand-Side Analysis notes are distinct from airport passenger traffic (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p27). The growth model in Chapter 2 runs from a third series, a 2025 base of 1,498,829 international arrivals (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p19).

The deliverables do not reconcile the three, so the report names the measure each time it cites an arrivals figure.

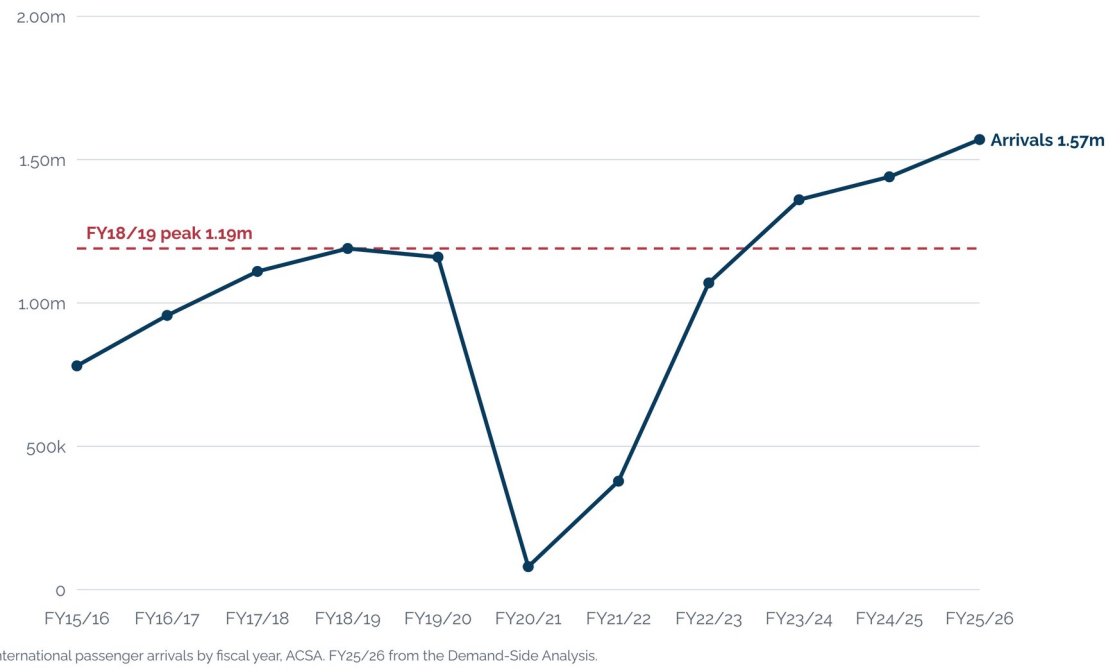


Figure 1.1. International passenger arrivals at Cape Town International passed their pre-pandemic peak in FY23/24 and reached 1.44m in FY24/25 and 1.57m in FY25/26.

Source: Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p25 (FY15/16 to FY24/25); Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p11 (FY25/26). CTIA and ACSA CPT passenger statistics, international arrivals by fiscal year.

Spend and value

Foreign direct spend in the province rose from R22.7bn in FY2024 to R25.9bn in FY2025, a gain of 14% in one year (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p11). The Western Cape earns that spend from a modest share of the national market. Across the four quarters of 2025 it took 16%, 13%, 13% and 16% of South Africa's foreign arrivals and 26%, 20%, 22% and 27% of foreign direct spend (p11).

The gap between the two shares is the province's premium. About a quarter of national spend from about a seventh of arrivals means the average foreign visitor to the Western Cape spends roughly 1.6 times the national average (computed from p11). The province earns about US$890 per international arrival, against US$500 for the rest of South Africa and US$630 for Morocco, though below Kenya's US$1,460 (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p15).

More than a quarter of overseas visitors stay between 7 and 21 days, on printed bands that sum to only 48% (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p12). Some 5% stay 1 to 2 days, 12% 3 to 4, 14% 7 to 10, 3% 11 to 14, 13% 15

to 21 and 1% other (p12). The Diagnostic prints the same distribution from the 2024 Wesgro Visitor Tracking Survey, in which 52.33% of respondents gave no length of stay, so the bands describe about half the sample (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p25).

The modal visitor in the 2024 Wesgro survey spends R1,000 to R2,000 a day, is aged 36 to 50 and travels as a pair (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p25). Nearly 40% spend more than R1,000 a day (p27). Self-catering at 17.4% and guesthouses at 9.7% lead accommodation choice, ahead of hotels at 3.6% (p27).

Source markets

Five markets supply 63% of overseas arrivals. In 2025 the UK held 19%, Germany 17%, the USA 16%, the Netherlands 7% and France 4%, and the three largest alone held 52% (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p13). The same slide prints 61% in its text; the report uses 63%, the sum of the printed shares, and logs the conflict.

Concentration is not new. On the Cape Town overseas air-arrivals basis for January to August 2024 the same five markets held 61%, with the UK and the USA at 18% each and Germany at 15% (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p29). The growth markets remain small: India supplied about 2.6% of South Africa's overseas tourists in September 2025, the Middle East 2.3% and China 1.4% (p30).

The mature markets also pay the most. Average spend per visitor in 2024 ran from R32,900 for the USA, R26,500 for the UK and R25,600 for Germany down to R8,600 for Namibia and R8,500 for Zimbabwe (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p14). The spread is 3.9 times, and the two regional markets compensate with stability, repeat demand and counter-seasonal volume (p14).

Most of these visitors arrive through someone else's hub. The UAE route carried 222,923 air arrivals into Cape Town in 2025, the UK 158,448, Qatar 126,078, Ethiopia 123,250 and Turkiye 89,090 (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p13). The four hub routes through Dubai, Doha, Addis Ababa and Istanbul carried 53% of arrivals on the ten largest routes (computed from p13), so the hubs, not the source markets, are the province's working gateways.

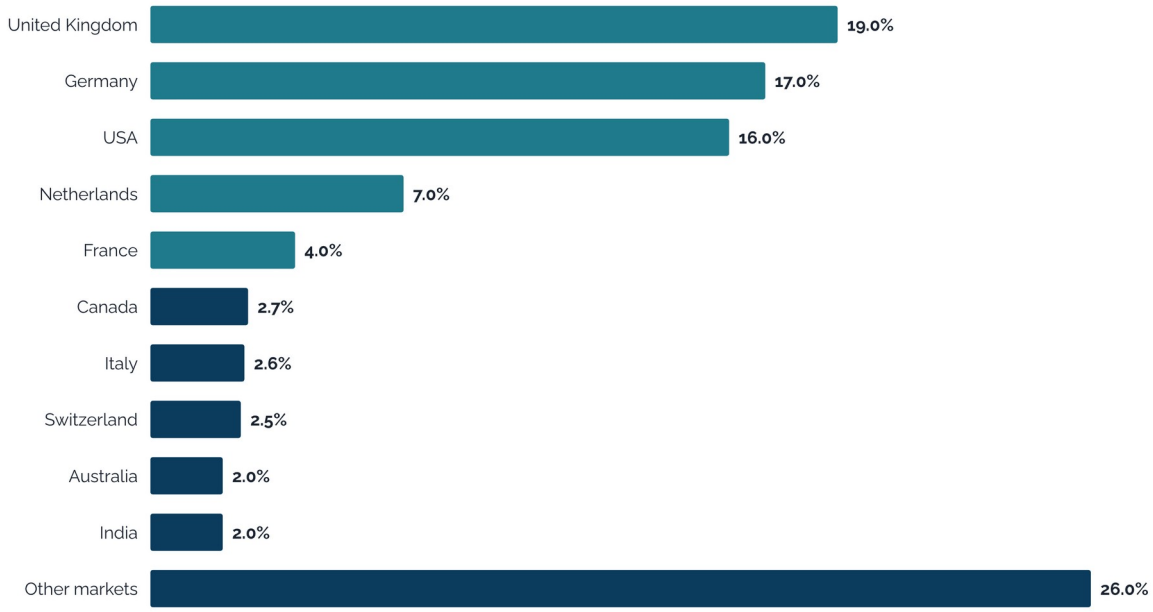


Figure 1.2. Five markets supplied 63% of overseas arrivals in 2025, and the UK, Germany and the USA alone supplied 52%.

Source: Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p13 (Stats SA and SAT International Performance Report 2025). The same slide prints 61% in its text; the five shares shown sum to 63%.

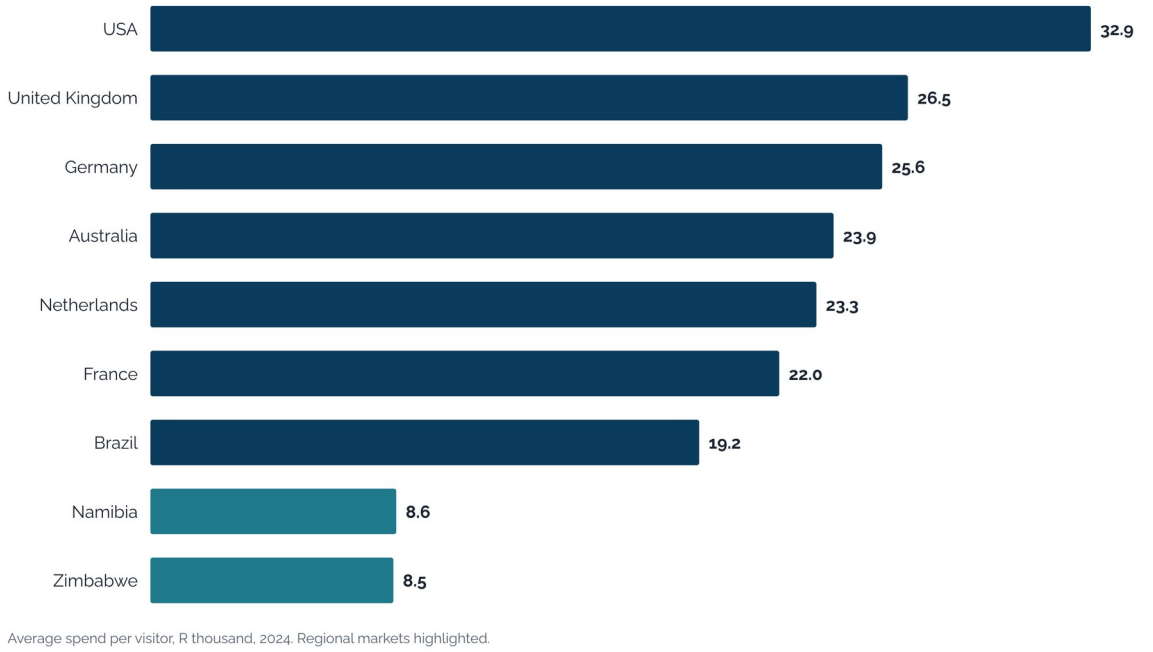


Figure 1.3. Average spend per visitor in 2024 ranged from R32,900 for the USA to R8,500 for Zimbabwe, a spread of 3.9 times.

Source: Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p14 (Stats SA and SAT International Performance Report). Average spend in the Western Cape by source market, ZAR, 2024.

Seasonality

Demand peaks in the southern summer. In 2025, 12.7% of overseas visitors travelled in December, 11.5% in January and 11.3% in November, against 6.1% in June and 6.5% in August (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p12). October to March together account for about 65% of the year.

That 65% is derived, not printed. The twelve monthly shares on the 2025 slide sum to 104.9%, so the October to March figure is provisional and flagged wherever it appears [Wesgro Research to confirm the 2025 month-of-travel shares]. The 2024 Wesgro Visitor Tracking Survey, whose monthly shares sum to 100%, gives 61% for October to March and 39% for April to September (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p25, p32).

Supply follows the same curve. June carries 6.4% of 2025 international seat capacity into Cape Town (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "Seasonality"), and Cape Town hotel occupancy was 53% in June 2023 (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p34). The Diagnostic drew the conclusion early: growth "will depend on improving conversion in Apr-Sep rather than pushing incremental demand into already busy peak months" (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p32).

Table 1.3. Six summer months, October to March, carry between 61% and 65% of overseas visitors' travel in the two years for which month of travel is recorded.

Year	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec	Oct to Mar
2024	9%	13%	12%	8%	7%	4%	6%	7%	7%	10%	10%	7%	61%
2025 (provisional)	11.5%	9.9%	10.3 %	6.9%	6.8%	6.1%	6.7%	6.5%	7.0%	9.2%	11.3%	12.7%	65%

Source: 2024: Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p25 and p32 (Wesgro Visitor Tracking Survey 2024; shares sum to 100%). 2025: Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p12 (Stats SA and SAT 2025; the printed shares sum to 104.9%, so the 2025 row and its October to March share are provisional).

Air and sea access

Ten airlines fly to Cape Town International from Africa, nine from Europe, three from North and South America, two from the Middle East and one from Asia (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p35). The aviation assessment states the gap plainly as "the absence of any direct capacity to any of the Asian markets", India and China included (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "The Capetown Market"). Twenty-nine international routes serve the airport in 2026 (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "Executive Summary").

Cape Town International itself is now the physical ceiling. One runway with no parallel taxiway caps movements at about 30 an hour, and ACSA's programme of about R11.3bn brings relief only from about 2032 to 2034 (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p101 to p103). The secondary gateways do not change the picture: George, above its design limit at 911,000 passengers in 2025, doubles by 2028 (p104, p105), and Cape Winelands Airport targets 2028 with no named carrier (p106, p107).

Cruise has grown without new berth capacity. The province hosted 70, 67 and 79 vessels in the 2022/23, 2023/24 and 2024/25 seasons, carrying 144,125, 109,884 and 127,178 passengers (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p37). The Infrastructure Report counts 83 calls at the Cape Town berth in 2024/25, 127,000 passengers and R1.79bn of economic impact (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p110). [StratEcon 2024/25 cruise report to confirm whether 79 vessels and 83 calls differ by definition.]

Port reliability, not berth space, is the risk. The single berth ran at about 40% of a season capacity of 150 or more calls, and its limits are a 300m ship length and the South-Easter wind (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p110). The Diagnostic calls the Port of Cape Town "a binding constraint, with congestion and equipment failures affecting export and cruise reliability" (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p34).

Geography of the system

The Cape Metro generates 72.5% of provincial GDPR, a whole-economy share rather than a tourism one (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p39; Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p22). The Cape Winelands follows at 11.2%, the Garden Route at 7.6%, the West Coast at 4.8%, the Overberg at 3% and the Central Karoo at 0.5% (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p42 to p50). The decks date only the Garden Route share, to 2023, while the Metro chart is titled 2024 and the rest carry no year (p39, p42).

Tourism supply is concentrated in the same way. The Infrastructure Report mapped 50,332 tourism assets across the six regions, of which the Metro holds 20,281, or 40.3% (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p2, p23). The Garden Route holds 9,875, the Cape Winelands 7,730, the Overberg 6,176, the West Coast 4,752 and the Central Karoo 1,518 (p34, p45, p56, p67, p78).

Cape Town is the axle of the system, "the province's global shopfront and primary dispersal hub" in the Infrastructure Report's words (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p22). The Diagnostic warns that "any capacity failure in Cape Town quickly becomes a provincial risk, not just a city problem" (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p41). International visitors land there and disperse from there, and readiness falls with each step away: accessibility scores drop from 4.7 in the Metro to 1.0 in the Central Karoo (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p88 to p90).

Beyond the Metro the visitor drives. The N2 is "the only continuous inter-regional tourism corridor, creating a single point of failure", and large parts of the province outside the Metro and the Garden Route remain effectively car-only destinations (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p98, p99). The further from Cape Town, the faster the infrastructure falls away (p90).

Table 1.4. The Cape Metro holds 72.5% of provincial GDPR and 40% of the province's tourism assets, and accessibility falls with each step away from it.

District	Share of provincial GDPR	Tourism assets	Share of assets	Accessibility score (1 to 5)
Cape Metro	72.5%	20,281	40.3%	4.7
Cape Winelands	11.2%	7,730	15.4%	3.3
Garden Route	7.6%	9,875	19.6%	3.0
West Coast	4.8%	4,752	9.4%	1.7
Overberg	3%	6,176	12.3%	2.0
Central Karoo	0.5%	1,518	3.0%	1.0
Western Cape		50,332	100%	

Source: GDPR shares: Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p39, p42, p44, p46, p48, p50 (year not printed; Garden Route share is for 2023). Asset counts: Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p2, p23, p34, p45, p56, p67, p78 (the Winelands gauge misprints 40.3%; 7,730 of 50,332 is 15.4%). Accessibility: Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p88 to p90, attractions and services basis; the Metro scores 5.0 on transport.

Rail, roads and utilities

Passenger rail has collapsed as a mode. Trainsets fell from about 110 in 1995 to about 91, pushing some 400,000 commuters onto saturated roads, and congestion in the Metro costs an estimated R2.8bn a year (Current State

Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p38). Metrorail still runs 460km, five lines and 104 of 121 stations, with 22.7m passenger trips in FY2025, but no line reaches the airport and it is rated functionally unusable for tourism (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p100, p90).

Utilities cap the periphery before demand does. Water scarcity in high-growth nodes such as the Garden Route acts as a "hard ceiling" for visitor load, and load shedding raises costs and degrades the experience in peripheral districts (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p38). The airport has no fuel pipeline and depends on road tankers (p38), and the 2017 to 2018 water crisis left a lasting perception of resource pressure (p55).

The remedies are named but not scheduled. The Diagnostic lists four transport enablers, none dated or costed: the Cape Town Integrator, rail restoration and devolution, a high-speed city to airport link and George to Cape Winelands passenger rail (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p38). PRASA's R21.1bn programme and the City's R123bn, 30-year devolution case cover fleet and lines, and neither carries a tourism product or an airport link (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p100).

Institutions

Wesgro runs the demand side of this system through six units: Cape Town Air Access, Cruise Cape Town, the Convention Bureau, Destination Marketing, Research and Tourism (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p7). Around them sit fifteen external organisations, from national agencies and state-owned entities to the province, the City, destination and attraction bodies and private operators (p7). The table below sets out who holds what.

The levers that bind the system sit at different tiers. National government holds visa rules, border compliance, air service agreements and route rights (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p58). The province holds jobs, inclusion and spatial outcomes, sector development and infrastructure planning; local government holds service delivery, precinct management and events readiness; industry holds route viability, demand generation and product standards (p58).

Alignment across those tiers is thin. The Diagnostic records specific dysfunctions, "SAT is in turmoil" among them, and the added pressure of a lack of fiscal space (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p58). More than twenty bodies produce tourism data and "there is no single view of visitor behaviour, making strategy reactive rather than predictive" (p56, p57).

Stakeholders say the same. Fifteen of the sixteen organisations interviewed raised industry and government collaboration (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p20 to p46; the count is of organisations with at least one insight under the theme). The Department of Economic Development named restrictive bilateral air agreements and destination funding materially below peer destinations as high-impact constraints (p24, p25).

Table 1.5. Wesgro's six units sit inside a system of fifteen external organisations whose decision rights are split across three spheres of government and industry.

Group	Organisations	What sits here
Wesgro units	Cape Town Air Access; Cruise Cape Town; Convention Bureau; Destination Marketing; Research; Tourism	Route development, cruise, business events bids, destination marketing, research and tourism promotion for Cape Town and the Western Cape

Group	Organisations	What sits here
Provincial and city government	Western Cape Government (Economic Development and Tourism); City of Cape Town	Provincial tier: jobs, inclusion and spatial outcomes; sector development and safety programmes; infrastructure planning and resilience. Local tier: service delivery and precinct management; events readiness and place experience; congestion, by-laws and community impact
National agencies and state-owned entities	South African Tourism; Airports Company South Africa; Transnet; South African Maritime Safety Authority	National tier: visa rules and border compliance; air service agreements and route rights; national brand and investment priorities. Airport capacity and port operations
Destination and attraction bodies	Cape Town Tourism; V&A Waterfront; CapeNature; South African National Parks; Table Mountain Aerial Cableway	Industry tier: demand generation and destination marketing; product quality and visitor experience at the flagship sites
Private operators	MSC Cruises; Cape Grace; Pullman Hotels and Resorts (Cape Town City Centre); Southern Sun	Industry tier: route and product viability and commercial performance; pricing and service standards

Source: Inception Report, Nov 2025, p7 (organisations as shown on the stakeholder map; the grouping is this report's); Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p58 (functions by tier).

None of these constraints is a shortage of visitors. The runway, the single corridor, a rail network visitors cannot use, the thin winter schedule and decision rights split across three tiers all sit outside a marketing budget. The system has recovered; its constraints are now physical and institutional.

1.3 From recovery to growth

The recovery is complete, and the growth that follows is capped by supply rather than demand.

The limits of recovery logic

The study set out in December 2025 to move the destination from recovery to growth; the hypothesis tree's own framing reads that "the Western Cape must transition from recovery to growth" (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p62). The first half of that task is done. International passenger arrivals at Cape Town International reached 1.44m in FY24/25 against 1.16m in FY19/20, and 1.57m in FY25/26 (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p11).

Recovery logic assumed capacity waiting to be refilled. Arrivals fell to 80,400 in FY20/21 (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p11), and the task was to refill idle seats, rooms and routes. That slack is gone. South Africa's international seat capacity is back at pre-pandemic levels, and Cape Town International runs the highest average load factor of the country's five largest airports, 79% in 2025 (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "The South African Market").

Cape Town did more than refill its seats. It added 17 mainline international routes between 2015 and 2025, more than any of eight peer airports, and MIDAS calls the result "a 'what next' moment" (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "International Comparisons"; "In Conclusion"). The rebound that a recovery plan is built to capture has already happened.

Demand without seats

Growth is now supply-constrained, not demand-constrained. Skift's survey of 34 outbound markets counts 97 million high-value, South Africa-interested travellers, of whom only 1.4 million convert into arrivals (Market

Assessment Report, May 2026, p41). The report's conclusion is that "the challenge is not demand generation but improving conversion into actual visits" (p41).

The binding supply is seats. Current air access places a hard ceiling at 1.8 million inbound seats, and the base case, in which Wesgro maintains current activity, reaches 1,802,929 arrivals at the 2030 plotted year (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p20). The chart below sets the base case against that ceiling.

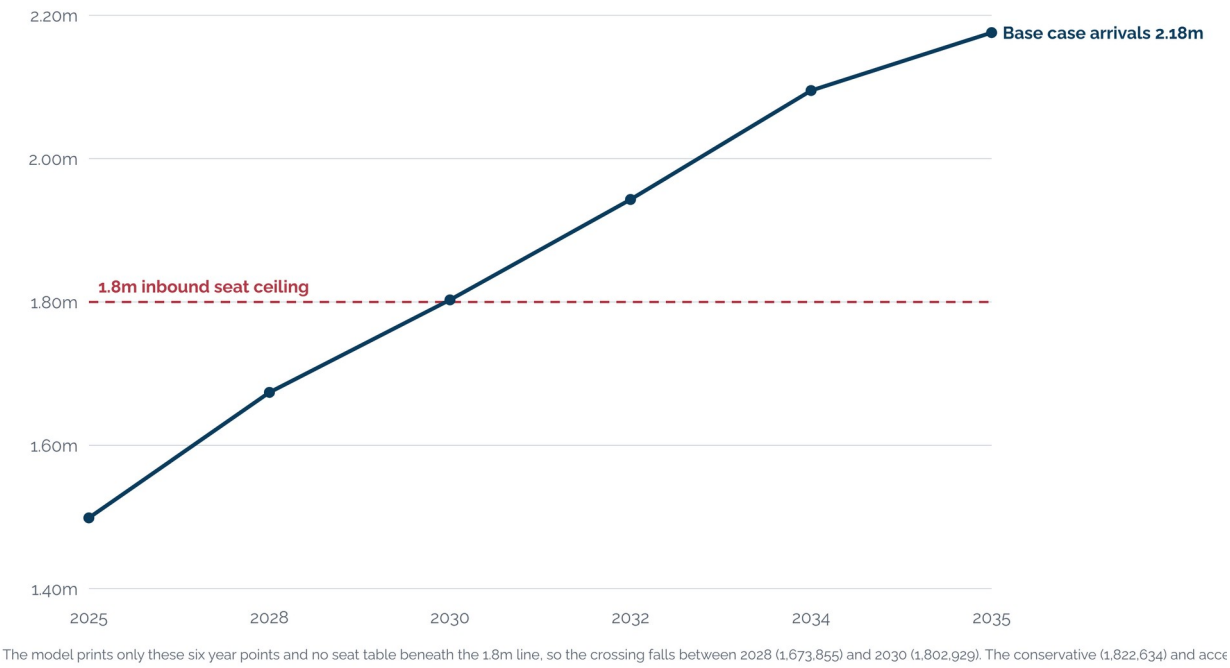


Figure 1.4. The base case crosses the 1.8m inbound seat ceiling at the 2030 plotted year, two years before the earliest relief at Cape Town International.

Source: Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p20 (base case by year from a 2025 base of 1,498,829; the 2028 to 2035 points are identical in the Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p21). Seat ceiling as drawn on the same slide. Airport relief from about 2032: Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p103.

The routes that exist are full. Eleven of the 27 international routes in the load-factor table ran above 80% in the year to November 2025, and the network averaged 76.0% on the printed total (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "Seasonality"). Five of the eleven are mature long-haul routes, led by Newark at 88.6%, Atlanta at 84.3% and Frankfurt and London Heathrow at 83.0% ("Seasonality").

Full routes do not add seats of their own accord. MIDAS expects that "rather than increase capacity carriers will seek to increase revenues via higher selling fares rather than add new services" (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "In Conclusion"). Airlines also pull seats out of winter: June carries 6.4% of the year's international capacity and December 10.8% ("Seasonality").

Behind the routes sits the runway. "The airport, not a shortage of visitors is what now caps Cape Town's tourism growth" (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p101). One runway with no parallel taxiway caps movements at about 30 an hour, and ACSA's programme of about R11.3bn brings relief only from about 2032 (p101 to p103).

The alternatives do not close the gap in time. George, domestic only, doubles by 2028, and Cape Winelands Airport targets 2028 with no named carrier. In the Infrastructure Report's words, "the certain fix is the latest, and the earliest big-capacity option is the least certain" (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p104 to p109). Route rights sit a tier up: air service agreements are a national function (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p58). The

Department of Economic Development rates restrictive bilateral agreements a high-impact constraint on airlift (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p24).

Car-only regions and unbookable product

Beyond the Metro the constraint changes shape, not nature. Accessibility scores fall from 4.7 in the Cape Metro to 1.0 in the Central Karoo (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p88 to p90). Large parts of the province outside the Metro and the Garden Route remain effectively car-only destinations (p99). The further from Cape Town, the faster the infrastructure falls away (p90).

Much of what the car can reach cannot be booked. Most rural properties have no OTA presence and Route 62 has the lowest online bookability of the six touring routes (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p95, p87). Even CapeNature takes about 70% of its reservations through a call centre rather than its online platform (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p42).

Growth above the norm

Global tourism grows 3 to 5% a year under stable conditions, the band the Benchmarking Report calls organic growth (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p7). Five of the six comparator destinations grew faster (p9). Chile grew about 35%, Singapore about 19%, Kenya 12.8 to 14.6%, Valencia 13 to 14% and New Zealand about 12%. New Zealand's figure matches its 2025 holiday-arrivals growth rather than the 5.9% for total arrivals in 2025 (p53). Melbourne's 4.3% is an Australia-wide forecast rather than an actual (p9, p17), so the comparator range runs from about 4% to 35%.

The Western Cape's two paths straddle the band. The base case implies 3.8% a year from 2025 to 2035 and the accelerated case 5.3%, and the accelerated case reverts to base "without confirmed routes" (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p19). The Benchmarking Report counts growth as structural only above that band. It must also be "driven by deliberate changes to demand drivers, access conditions or product systems, rather than cyclical recovery or short-term promotion" (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p8).

Cape Town is the axle of the system: international visitors arrive there and disperse from there, and "Cape Town remains the engine of the system, but growth cannot keep concentrating there" (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p114). The Department of Economic Development already reads the growth framing as overweight on volumes and asks for a value and spend lens in place of arrivals (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p24). Growth now needs new markets, new seasons and new regions, and each of those is a supply problem before it is a marketing problem.

1.4 Approach and method

The study ran in four phases from November 2025, tested one hypothesis tree against every interim deliverable and took each figure from a ranked hierarchy of sources.

Four phases

The Inception Report set out four phases with printed durations: inception, one month; demand-side analysis, four months; supply-side analysis, three months; enablement and final reporting, seven months (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p11). The Phase 4 detail slide prints six months for the same phase (p22); the report uses

seven, which matches the Phase 4 bar on the deliverables gantt, May to the end of November (p12). The deliverables gantt runs November to November without printing years (p12).

Each phase had a distinct job (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p11). Inception aligned expectations and ways of working and produced the Current State Diagnostic as a literature-based baseline (p14). The demand phase covered source markets, India and China route to market, benchmarks and trends; the supply phase covered spatial readiness and community inclusion, and the two overlapped from February to April (p12, p18, p19).

The final phase built the M&E framework, consolidated the strategy into this report and prepared the launch (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p22, p23). Three mechanisms governed the work: fortnightly working sessions with Wesgro, Steering Committee sessions at milestones and fortnightly written status updates (p27). The session calendar ran from the kick-off on 13 November 2025 to a final-report Steerco pencilled for 12 June 2026 (p13).

The hypothesis tree

The analytical core is a hypothesis tree agreed in December 2025 and tested by every workstream since. The Current State Diagnostic printed it with three pillars, six themes and eighteen entries (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p64). The pillars are Reshape Demand, Transform Supply and Build Enabling Capability, each carrying two themes.

The tree disciplined the evidence. The Stakeholder Insights Report mapped all 223 of its insight statements to tree entries before aggregating them (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p5, p20 to p46). The later deliverables reprinted the tree as a recap and marked the branch they addressed.

Three entries changed wording between December 2025 and March 2026 (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p7). The seasonality entry gained mega events; the institutional entry widened from Wesgro, DEDAT and CTT to local, provincial and national; the collaboration entry added public and private. No document in hand dates the change more closely than the 23 January working session and the 6 February Steerco (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p13).

The 14 October 2026 review updated the tree to twenty focus areas and gave each a disposition [Summary of Findings, 14 Oct 2026, pp15 to 16: deck not in hand; page citation to confirm]. The three pillars and six themes stand. The Infrastructure Report of 22 September still carried the eighteen-entry tree, so the move to twenty belongs to the final review rather than to any one workstream (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p2).

The entries moved in three ways; first, the air access and cruise entry split in two, because the aviation assessment and the Infrastructure Report showed them to be different problems. Second, the infrastructure, visa and safety entry moved from the supply pillar to governance, because its levers sit with national government. Third, a workforce and service skills entry was added and flagged, because the 300,000-jobs ambition has no labour analysis behind it (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p4).

Six further entries were reworded to the lever the evidence supports and one was refined; the table below lists each change and the workstream behind it. Ten entries carried through as Validated with title-only edits. Chapter 3 records every disposition and section 1.5 defines the labels [Summary of Findings, 14 Oct 2026, slide 14: the deck's own change count and label definitions to confirm].

Table 1.6. Eight December entries changed scope, place or form by October 2026, one focus area was added and ten carried through as Validated.

December 2025 entry	October 2026 focus area	Change	Workstream behind it
Close the Air Access and Cruise Capacity Gaps	Win direct routes and add seats on full routes; Grow cruise calls and ports	Split; air Reworded, cruise New	MIDAS route loads and fares-before-seats finding; Infrastructure Report cruise and ports section
Lead Removal of Infrastructure, Visa and Safety Deficits	Same title, under Governance and leadership	Moved from theme 2.1 to 3.2	Stakeholder Insights, Demand-Side barriers and MIDAS place visas and air rights with national government
No December entry	Develop workforce and service skills	New; Flagged, untested	No workstream; the 300,000-jobs ambition has no labour analysis behind it
Develop the Seasonality and Spread Proposition	Create green-season demand with MICE and events	Reworded	MIDAS seasonality; Demand-Side MICE landscape
Facilitate Adoption Along the Path to Purchase	Make the whole province findable and bookable	Reworded	Inclusion Plan, Stakeholder Insights and Infrastructure Report on product that cannot be found or booked
Pivot to Growth Markets (China, India, ME, ASEAN)	Convert India and China hub traffic	Reworded	Demand-Side route to market and MIDAS hub volumes
Ensure Sustainable Destination Management	Manage climate risk and sustainable tourism	Reworded	Stakeholder Insights on LTO funding and climate losses; Inclusion Plan De Rust profile
Review Institutional Arrangements (Wesgro, DEDAT, CTT)	Align institutional stakeholders across all three tiers	Reworded	Stakeholder Insights on fragmented mandates; Diagnostic governance tiers
Drive Community and SME Inclusion	Embed local destination bodies for community inclusion	Refined	SME and Community Inclusion Plan

Source: Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p64 for the December entries; dispositions as recorded at the 14 October 2026 review (Summary of Findings, 14 Oct 2026, pp15 to 16) [deck page reference to be confirmed].

Source hierarchy

Every figure in this report carries a source and page, and sources rank in five tiers. Where tiers disagree the higher tier wins; where two documents in one tier disagree, both values are recorded and the value used is stated with the reason. Nothing is reconciled by averaging.

1. Interim deliverables, cited by the date printed on the cover and by PDF page index, since none prints page numbers.
2. Working analyses: the Market Assessment Report of May 2026 and the three Skift memos on digital and search insights (December 2025), segmentation (March 2026) and African markets (March 2026), cited by section.
3. Wesgro and government data cited through a deliverable (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p34): the Mero 2024 reports for all six districts, the Pero 2025 and the Growth for Jobs Strategy 2023. The same tier holds the Tourism Blueprint, Wesgro's five-year strategy and the StratEcon cruise liner economic contribution studies for 2023, 2024 and 2024/25.
4. Benchmark and reference reports, such as the UN Tourism barometer behind the global growth norm (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p7).
5. External public sources, used only where no higher tier carries the figure and labelled as such.

Two conventions follow. The MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment and the Skift memos are Word files without page numbers, so they are cited by section title. The 14 October 2026 summary deck ranks below the deliverables: where the two differ, the deliverable's figure is used and the difference is logged.

The reconciliation behind this rule logged 55 discrepancies between the agreed structure and the deliverables, seven of them material. They concern the model base year, the October to March share, the routes above 80% load, the comparator growth range, the 2035 ambition, the cruise call baseline and the Infrastructure Report's date. Each is resolved where it is used, with both values shown.

Interim deliverables

Nine dated documents carry the evidence, and the table below dates each by its cover. Four carry a later file date than their cover, which the report records rather than hides. The Market Assessment Report of May 2026 is the working analysis behind the Demand-Side Analysis and alone prints the 2025 base the growth case uses (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p19).

Table 1.7. Nine dated documents carry the evidence and answer the SLA clauses the final report consolidates.

Document	Cover date	Version in hand	SLA clauses answered	Summarised in
Inception Report	Nov 2025	37 slides; working session of 28 November 2025; no tree printed	[to confirm against Annexure B]	1.1, 1.4
Current State Diagnostic	Dec 2025	v2 in the file name; December tree on p64	[to confirm against Annexure B]	1.2; folded into 2.1 and 2.5
Stakeholder Insights Report (phase 1)	Mar 2026	File dated 12 March 2026; sixteen organisation tables	1.1.6, 3.2.8	2.4
Global Benchmarking Report	Mar 2026	Cover prints 2026 only; file dated 24 March 2026	1.1.5, 1.1.11, 3.2.7	2.3
MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment	Mar 2026	Word file marked final draft, dated 20 April 2026; no page numbers	1.1.1.2	2.2
Market Assessment Report	May 2026	Working analysis; predecessor of the Demand-Side Analysis; prints the 2025 model base	Working analysis under 1.1.1 [to confirm]	2.1
Demand-Side Analysis	Jun 2026	Final; file dated 1 October 2026	1.1.1, 1.1.7, 3.2.3	2.1
Infrastructure Report	Jul 2026	Final of 114 slides, file dated 22 September 2026; June 2026 draft of 42 slides superseded	1.1.2, 1.1.8, 3.2.4	2.5
SME and Community Inclusion Plan	Sep 2026	File dated 9 October 2026	1.1.3, 1.1.9, 3.2.5	2.6

Source: Cover pages and file dates of each document; SLA Annexure B clause numbers as assigned in the agreed report structure of 2 November 2026 [to be checked against the signed Annexure B].

Stakeholder engagement

Stakeholder engagement ran in four phases alongside the analysis (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p4, p17). Introduction and framing ran from January to March 2026, sense-making and validation in April and May, strategy socialisation in June and July and mobilisation from August into October. The Stakeholder Insights Report closed the first phase with insight tables for sixteen organisations, from Mossel Bay to the CTICC (p20 to p46). Sixteen is a count of those tables; the report prints no tally.

The method was strict about what an insight is. Sessions were run, insights extracted, each mapped to a tree entry and then aggregated (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p5). The 223 statements are the project team's paraphrases rated High, Medium or Low, not quotations, so this report attributes them to organisations and never to named individuals (p5, p20 to p46).

Two gaps in the record matter: phase 1 engaged no airline, online travel agent or tour operator, and the six demand-side engagements were proposed for phase 2 (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p16). The demand work drew instead on discussions with more than 20 stakeholders of its own (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p7). The outcomes of engagement phases 2 to 4 sit in no document in hand [Letsema to supply the phase 2 to 4 engagement record for Appendix A6].

Data limits

Five limits in the data shape how the findings read. The headline arrivals series counts international passenger arrivals at Cape Town International, not tourists, and Cape Town air arrivals stand proxy for the province in the market shares (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p25, p26, p29). No approved methodology exists for provincial tourism GDP and jobs, and no deliverable prints a Western Cape tourism employment baseline (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p37).

[Supply dataset limits to confirm: neither part of the Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026 (p1 to p114) states that the dataset has no geography below district or that records added after May 2026 are placeholders; the source of this statement is needed.] The inclusion analysis runs on an OpenStreetMap asset layer, extracted on 16 September 2026, joined to Census 2011 sub-places, so its resident shares are fifteen years old (SME and Community Inclusion Plan, Sep 2026, p14 to p17, p22).

The growth model exists in two editions. The May Market Assessment runs from a 2025 base of 1,498,829 arrivals and the June Demand-Side Analysis from a 2024 base of 1,445,031 (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p19; Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p20). Both reach 2,175,778 in the base case and 2,516,282 in the accelerated case by 2035. The report runs the growth case from the 2025 base, keeps FY24/25's 1.44m as the recovery baseline and states which is which wherever both appear.

Completion plan

A six-week completion plan agreed on 12 October 2026 governs the last stage of the work. [Summary of Findings, 14 Oct 2026: six-week plan from 12 October, with weekly outputs and owners, to be inserted; deck not in hand.] It replaces the inception timetable, which placed report consolidation between 1 June and 27 July 2026 and launch support to 2 November (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p23). The report goes to Steerco, Exco and the Board before the public launch in February 2027.

1.5 How to read this report

The report is built so that a Board member can read the summary and any one focus area on its own, and a programme owner can run the plan from Chapters 3 to 5.

Chapter map

The report moves from context to evidence to recommendations to delivery, and the table below gives the route through it for each reader.

Table 1.8. Seven parts carry the report from the case in short to the evidence behind every figure, and each part has a primary reader.

Part	What it answers	Who should read it
Executive summary	The case in short: the growth case to 2035, the constraints that cap it, the twenty focus areas by pillar, the first 24 months and the headline indicators	Board, Exco and the February 2027 launch audience; it stands alone
1 Context	What Wesgro asked for, where the system stands after recovery, why the next step is supply-constrained and how the study ran	Every reader; the Board member who reads no other chapter of the body
2 Analysis summaries	What each interim deliverable asked, did and found, with the evidence that survived into the hypothesis tree	Readers checking the evidence behind a Chapter 3 entry; each section closes with a box naming the focus areas it supports
3 Findings and recommendations	For each of the twenty focus areas: the December hypothesis, its disposition, the evidence, what Wesgro does, what it asks of partners and what it escalates nationally	Board and Exco by entry; the programme owner in full; Section 3.4 for the sequence
4 Execution plan	Which initiatives, in what order, owned by whom, at what cost and with which decision gates	The programme owner, Steerco and the partners named in the RACI
5 Monitoring and evaluation	How progress is measured: indicators, baselines, targets, data sources, the scorecard and the 2030 mid-term review	Wesgro Research, the programme office and Steerco
Appendices A1 to A9	The traceability table, the demand model, the benchmark cases, readiness scores, the community fact base, stakeholder inputs, charters, the toolkit and references	Analysts and anyone checking a figure

Source: Letsema, structure of this report, November 2026.

Disposition labels

Each Chapter 3 entry records what the study believed in December 2025 and what the evidence did to that belief. The December tree held eighteen entries under three pillars and six themes (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p64); the tree settled at the 14 October 2026 review keeps the pillars and themes and holds twenty focus areas.

Table 1.9. Seven labels record what the evidence did to each December hypothesis, and ten of the twenty focus areas carry Validated.

Label	Meaning	Focus areas
Validated	The evidence confirmed the December hypothesis as written	10
Refined	The evidence confirmed the hypothesis and sharpened its content	1
Reworded	The evidence confirmed the hypothesis; the entry was renamed to what the evidence showed	6
New	Added in October 2026, with no December entry behind it	1
Moved	The evidence confirmed the hypothesis; the entry moved to another theme because its levers sit with another tier	1
Withdrawn	Dropped because the evidence did not support the hypothesis	0
Flagged	Untested; carried as a question for analysis still to be commissioned	1

Source: Dispositions as recorded at the 14 October 2026 review (Summary of Findings, 14 Oct 2026, pp15 to 16) [deck page reference to be confirmed against the final deck]; counts from the traceability table in Appendix A1.

The counts sum to twenty. Lead removal of infrastructure, visa and safety deficits carries Moved: it keeps its December wording but moves from supply theme 2.1 to governance theme 3.2, because its levers sit nationally. [Summary of Findings deck, 14 Oct 2026, to confirm the label for the moved entry and that nothing was Withdrawn]

Citations and figures

Every figure carries its source and page in the form (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p21). The date is the cover date and the page is the PDF page index counted from the cover, because none of the decks prints page numbers. The MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment and the three Skift memos have no fixed pagination and are cited by section title.

Four cover dates differ from their file dates. The Demand-Side Analysis is cited as June 2026 though its file is dated 1 October 2026 and the Inclusion Plan cites a 16 September version. The Infrastructure Report cited is the July 2026 final, not the June draft. The SME and Community Inclusion Plan prints September 2026 on a file dated 9 October, and the MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment prints March 2026 on a file dated 20 April 2026.

Where two inputs disagree the report states the value it uses, names the other with its page and gives the reason. The five-market share, printed as both 63% and 61% on one slide, is one case (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p13). Nothing is averaged and nothing is reconciled silently.

Two arrivals figures recur and measure different things. The recovery baseline is 1.44m international passenger arrivals at Cape Town International in FY24/25, ACSA's fiscal-year count (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p25). The growth model runs from 1,498,829 arrivals in 2025 (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p19) to 2,175,778 in the base case and 2,516,282 in the accelerated case in 2035 (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p20).

The strategy's 2.5m is the accelerated case rounded. The word doubling appears only where the report quotes the original mandate (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p4).

Marks and codes

Highlighted text in square brackets marks an open item: a figure no input in hand carries, with the figure needed and who holds it. Every page of this draft carries DRAFT FOR DISCUSSION in its header and the cover carries a draft line; both come off at sign-off.

Three codes tie the chapters together. A Chapter 3 kicker names the entry's theme, 1.1 to 3.2, above the focus area name as it reads on the tree; each entry closes with the initiative and indicator it links to. Initiatives in Chapter 4 run I1 onwards in one sequence; indicators in Chapter 5 run T1-01 onwards for impact, T2-01 for outcome and T3-01 for output.

Appendix A1 holds the traceability table. For each focus area it records the pillar, theme, disposition and one-line reason, the December entry it descends from, the workstream behind the disposition and its initiative and indicator codes. Any Chapter 3 claim can be followed back to a page and forward to an owner and a measure.

Analysis summaries

2.1 Demand-side analysis and market strategy

Concentration, seasonality and seats cap growth before demand does, and the base case meets the 1.8m inbound seat ceiling by 2030.

What was asked

The demand workstream was asked where Western Cape demand comes from, where growth will come from and how Wesgro should pursue it. The inception report framed the phase as a deep dive into priority markets to uncover growth levers from real-world demand and travel barriers (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p11).

It had two parts (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p15). Market assessments were to prioritise source markets by volume, spend and air access and profile the traveller types within them. Route-to-market analysis for India and China was to test visas, air connectivity and the visibility of Western Cape product on global channels.

The agreed report structure assigns this work to SLA Annexure B clauses 1.1.1, 1.1.7 and 3.2.3. [Clause wording to be checked against the signed Annexure B.]

What was done

Two decks carry the work. The Market Assessment Report of May 2026 set the baseline, the growth model, route to market and the traveller segments (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p2). The Demand-Side Analysis of June 2026 carried the model forward and added the African opportunity and the business-events landscape (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p26, p31).

Three methods supply the evidence (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p7). Skift's 2025 values-based survey covered more than 25,000 travellers in 34 outbound markets, 17 of them Wesgro priority markets, with 800 to 1,600 respondents a market (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p40). Desk review drew on Wesgro reports, Statistics South Africa and Google search data, and more than 20 stakeholder discussions added market-facing judgement (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p7).

The growth model builds a rate for each source market from four levers (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p18). They are outbound growth in the market, the Western Cape's penetration of it, the airlift ceiling and structural conditions such as currency and visas. It anchors on OAG aviation data for access and Skift traveller data for demand (p8). Its three scenarios vary the intervention, not the demand: "the difference between scenarios is not demand potential, but the extent to which structural barriers are removed" (p19).

The two decks print the same 2035 points from different bases. The May deck runs from a 2025 base of 1,498,829 and the June deck from a 2024 base of 1,445,031 (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p19; Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p20). This report uses the 2025 base and logs the difference.

The Current State Diagnostic of December 2025 supplied the baseline folded in here: source-market concentration, the seasonal profile and the first segment work (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p16 to p20, p29, p32). Its figures are cited where they add to the later decks.

Findings that survived into the tree

1. Five markets carry the province. The UK, Germany, the USA, the Netherlands and France supplied 63% of overseas arrivals in 2025, and the first three alone 52% (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p13). The same slide prints 61% in its text; the report uses 63%, the sum of the printed shares. The December baseline showed the same pattern, with the top five at 61% of Cape Town overseas air arrivals from January to August 2024 (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p29).

Those markets also pay the most. Average spend per visitor in 2024 ran from R32,900 for the USA and R26,500 for the UK down to R8,600 for Namibia and R8,500 for Zimbabwe (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p14). The deck's own reading is that high-spend visitors come from Europe and North America, "tying future value growth to slower-growing source markets" (p14).

2. Six months carry nearly two thirds of the year. December, January and November were the peak months of 2025 at 12.7%, 11.5% and 11.3% of overseas visitors, while June fell to 6.1% (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p12). October to March hold about 65% on that table, a provisional figure because its twelve shares sum to 104.9%. On a Cape Town overseas air-arrivals basis for January to August 2024 the split was 61% and 39% (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p25).

The deck draws the conclusion that matters for strategy. Growth depends on "improving conversion in Apr-Sep rather than pushing incremental demand into already busy peak months" (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p25).

3. Demand supports 2.18m to 2.52m arrivals by 2035. From the 2025 base, the model projects 1,822,634 arrivals in the conservative case, 2,175,778 in the base case and 2,516,282 in the accelerated case, implied growth of 2.0%, 3.8% and 5.3% a year (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p19). The step from base to accelerated rests on confirmed direct routes to India and China, above-baseline activation and more hub capacity into Cape Town (p18). The model states the dependency plainly: "without confirmed routes, volume reverts to base" (p19).

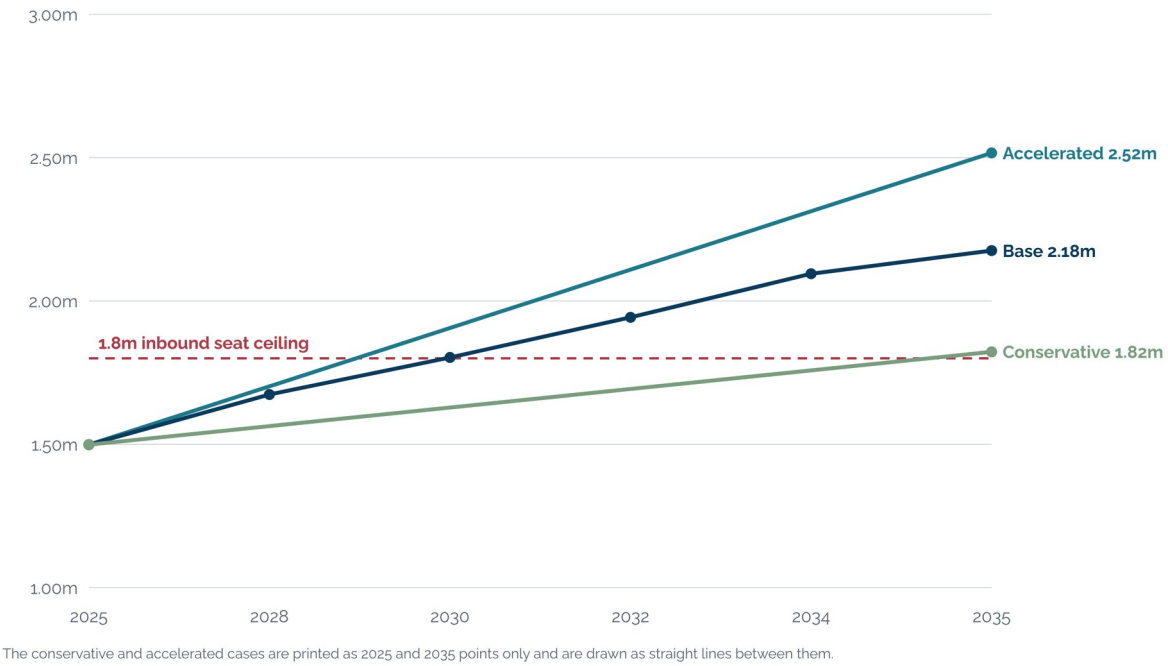


Figure 2.1. The base case passes the 1.8m inbound seat ceiling at the 2030 year point, and only the accelerated case reaches 2.5m by 2035.

Source: Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p19 (scenario end points) and p20 (base-case year points and the seat ceiling as drawn). OAG Aviation Analytics.

In the base case the hubs add the most arrivals and the acceleration markets grow fastest. Between 2025 and 2035 hub markets add 206,584 arrivals, mature markets 178,780, acceleration markets 175,818, regional markets 110,298 and Japan and South Korea 5,469 (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p20, computed). India more than doubles from 76,547 to 165,260 and China with Hong Kong from 43,412 to 92,598, both at 8% a year (p22).

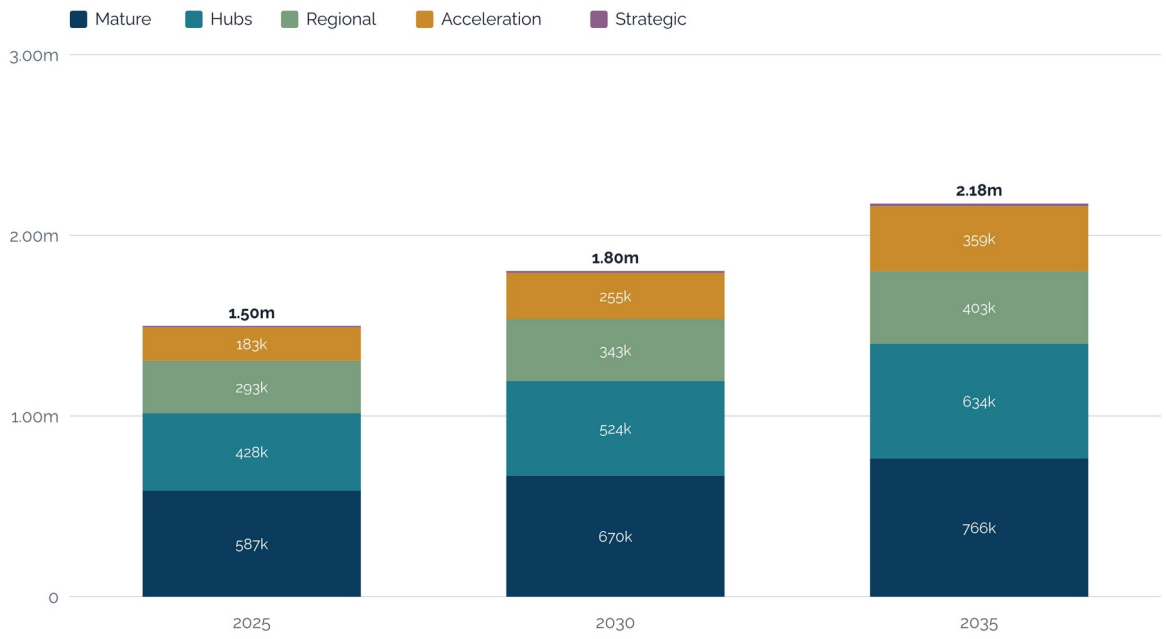


Figure 2.2. Hub and acceleration markets supply 382,402 of the 676,949 arrivals the base case adds between 2025 and 2035.

Source: Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p20. Groups as printed: Mature (UK, Germany, USA, Netherlands, France, Switzerland); Hubs (UAE, Ethiopia, Qatar, Turkey); Regional (Namibia, Zimbabwe, Zambia, Botswana, Kenya and others); Acceleration (Gulf, China, India, Brazil); Strategic (Japan, South Korea).

Spend follows the mix. At fixed average spend per group, from R24,500 a visitor in mature markets to R8,500 in regional ones, base-case foreign spend rises from a modelled R27.12bn in 2024 to R40.59bn in 2035 (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p24).

4. Seats bind before demand does. The model draws current air access as "a hard ceiling at 1.8 million inbound seats", and the base case first passes it at the 2030 year point with 1,802,929 arrivals (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p20). Only six year points are printed, so the crossing falls between 2028, at 1,673,855, and 2030. The deck judges 2.1 million by 2035 achievable only with deliberate intervention to add capacity (p20).

5. Four segments fit the province, and each has a home market. Skift's survey identifies four values-based segments most aligned with the Western Cape, together about 97 million addressable travellers (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p41 to p43). The deck marks the pairs to pursue: Curious Explorers in the UK and the USA, Creative Connectors in India, Discerning Connoisseurs in China and the UAE and Reflective Adventurers in Germany (p43). Curious Explorers and Discerning Connoisseurs are "most aligned to the Western Cape's offering" (p4).

Table 2.1. Four segments hold about 97 million addressable travellers, and the deck pairs each with the markets where it is most concentrated.

Segment	Addressable travellers	What drives them	Priority markets	Long-haul trip spend
Curious Explorers	30m (31%)	Cultural immersion, learning and authentic connection	UK, USA	$4,800 to $6,200
Creative Connectors	25m (26%)	Design, food and urban creativity	India	$4,200 to $5,400
Discerning Connoisseurs	19m (20%)	Exclusivity, refinement and access	China, UAE	$8,500 to $14,000

Segment	Addressable travellers	What drives them	Priority markets	Long-haul trip spend
Reflective Adventurers	23m (23%)	Renewal and connection with nature	Germany	$4,600 to $5,900

Source: Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p42, p43, p45, p48, p51, p54. Priority pairs are the cells highlighted on p43. Trip spend is average long-haul trip spend as printed; the currency is not named on the slides.

The segments matter for spread as much as for volume. Curious Explorers offer the "strongest opportunity for geographic dispersal beyond Cape Town", and Reflective Adventurers have "strong potential to support seasonality mitigation" through year-round outdoor and wellness travel (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p56).

6. India and China already arrive, through other carriers' hubs. An estimated 71,000 travellers fly from India to Cape Town each year through connecting hubs and about 30,000 from China, together about 101,000 journeys (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p46, p48, computed). Addis Ababa and Dubai handle more than 80% of the Indian connections, and direct Indian service is "unlikely before 2030 due to aircraft constraints at Air India and IndiGo" (p48).

The barriers are named market by market (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p51). Chinese and Gulf travellers face slow, document-heavy visa processes; India has no direct flight to Mumbai or Delhi and thin Indian-friendly adaptation; the Gulf lacks Arabic-language booking and local-currency pricing.

Each market books through its own platforms. Chinese travellers discover on Douyin and Xiaohongshu and book on Trip.com, Qunar and Fliggy; Indian travellers book through MakeMyTrip, Booking.com and Expedia; much Gulf travel still runs through private advisors and concierge agencies (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p45, p47, p49; Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p34, p35). The deck's prescription is to activate inside those platforms and shift investment "toward trade-led conversion rather than broad awareness campaigns" (p55).

7. Africa is a base and a growth market at once. The Western Cape recorded 323,971 tourist arrivals from 16 reported African markets in 2024, 62% of them from Zimbabwe and Namibia (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p27). African visitors spent R4.2bn in the province in 2025, with Nigerians and Ghanaians spending most per visit at R31,000 and R27,700 (p29). Skift models Nigeria's addressable market at 310,000 to 510,000 adult trips a year and Kenya's at 240,000 to 400,000 (p28, p30).

The sources rank Ghana differently. The Demand-Side Analysis names Nigeria, Kenya and Ghana as priority markets (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p30), while Skift's memo places Ghana among its fourth-tier watch markets for brand seeding rather than conversion (Skift African Market Analysis memo, Mar 2026, section 2). Regional markets also steady the year: Namibia and Zimbabwe "add stability, repeat demand and counter-seasonal volume" (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p14).

8. Business events are the strongest green-season lever. International association meetings in Cape Town rose from 33 in 2022 to 58 in 2024, and 109 of the 136 meetings held over the three years fell between May and November (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p37, computed). Cape Town ranked 35th in the 2024 ICCA ranking and hosted 37 of South Africa's 64 UIA-recorded meetings in 2025 (p36, p38). Cape Town hotel occupancy was 53% in June 2023, the gap such events fill (p34).

The deck warns against a single target. Meetings, incentives, conventions and exhibitions have different buyers and lead times, and only conferences are measured well; meetings are "absent from consolidated provincial

statistics" (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p35, p36). Stellenbosch and George are named as credible secondary hubs, with delegates spending extra nights in the regions while major events stay in Cape Town (p41).

Table 2.2. Ten findings from the demand workstream carry into the hypothesis tree.

Finding	Figure	Source
Five markets dominate overseas arrivals	UK 19%, Germany 17%, USA 16%, Netherlands 7%, France 4%; top five 63% (61% in the slide text), 2025	DSA p13
Spend per visitor varies almost fourfold	USA R32,900 to Zimbabwe R8,500, 2024	DSA p14
Demand peaks in summer	October to March about 65%, 2025 (provisional; shares sum to 104.9%); 61%, Jan to Aug 2024, Cape Town overseas air arrivals	DSA p12; MA p25
Growth case to 2035	1,498,829 (2025) to 1,822,634, 2,175,778 or 2,516,282; 2.0%, 3.8% or 5.3% a year	MA p19
Seats bind by 2030	1.8m inbound seats; base case 1,673,855 in 2028 and 1,802,929 in 2030	MA p20
Hubs add most arrivals	Hubs +206,584; mature +178,780; acceleration +175,818; regional +110,298; strategic +5,469, 2025 to 2035	MA p20, computed
India and China arrive only via hubs	India about 71,000 and China about 30,000 journeys a year; direct Indian service unlikely before 2030	DSA p46, p48
Four segments, 97 million addressable	30m, 25m, 19m and 23m; priority pairs UK and USA, India, China and UAE, Germany	MA p43
African demand is large and high-yield at the top	323,971 arrivals (2024); R4.2bn spend (2025); Nigeria R31,000 and Ghana R27,700 a visit	DSA p27, p29
Business events fill the green season	ICCA meetings 33 (2022) to 58 (2024); 109 of 136 held May to November	DSA p37

Source: As cited in each row. MA: Market Assessment Report, May 2026. DSA: Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026.

What this means for the tree

Validates FA01, Respond to growth segment traveller preferences. Four segments, each with named home markets (finding 5).

Supports FA02, Create green-season demand with MICE and events. Business events cluster from May to November, when leisure demand is weakest (findings 2 and 8). The seat side of the case sits in 2.2.

Supports FA03, Make the whole province findable and bookable. Conversion runs through market-specific platforms that Western Cape product must reach (finding 6).

Rewords FA04, Convert India and China hub traffic. About 101,000 hub journeys a year and no direct Indian route before 2030 (finding 6).

Validates FA05, Increase yield in mature markets. The highest-spending visitors come from the slowest-growing markets (findings 1 and 3).

Validates FA06, Build a regional foundation (Africa). A large regional base and two high-yield growth markets (finding 7).

Supplies the binding constraint for FA07, Win direct routes and add seats on full routes, and the visa barriers for **FA19, Lead removal of infrastructure, visa and safety deficits** (findings 4 and 6).

2.2 Aviation market assessment

Airlines run Cape Town's full routes for yield rather than volume and withdraw seats in winter, so new seats must be won route by route.

What was asked

The aviation work answered the inception brief to review current airlift and planned route development as part of route to market (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p15). MIDAS Aviation set itself four questions (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "Introduction"). How well has the Western Cape developed new air services, and how does that record compare with similar markets? What challenges and opportunities do the next five years hold, and which emergent markets matter?

The agreed report structure assigns this work to SLA Annexure B clause 1.1.1.2. [Clause wording to be checked against the signed Annexure B.]

What was done

MIDAS measured scheduled seats and estimated bookings for every Cape Town route. Bookings come from the airlines' global distribution systems, weighted to the full market, and so "will not always reconcile exactly with airport published data" (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "The South African Market"). The latest annual booking set runs to November 2025 ("Seasonality").

Cape Town was compared with eight secondary airports chosen for peripheral geography and inbound tourism: Calgary, Christchurch, Edinburgh, Keflavik, Larnaca, Marrakech, Santiago and Valencia (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "International Comparisons"). The report is a Word file without page numbers, so it is cited here by section.

The Infrastructure Report of July 2026 assessed the physical side of access: Cape Town International, George, the proposed Cape Winelands airport and the secondary airfields (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p101 to p109). Its airport findings are summarised here because they set the ceiling the airlines fly into; its spatial findings sit in 2.5.

Findings that survived into the tree

1. Cape Town has already won its routes. Twenty-nine international routes serve the airport in 2026, and Cape Town added 17 mainline international services between 2015 and 2025, more than Santiago (14), Valencia (12) or Calgary (8) (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "Executive Summary"; "International Comparisons"). The body of the report counts fourteen new routes since 2014, a difference this report logs. Cape Town's share of South Africa's international capacity rose from 10% in 2010 to 25% ("The Capetown Market").

MIDAS calls the result "a 'what next' moment" (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "In Conclusion"). Tactical gains remain in frequency and aircraft size. The next phase needs a strategy that "looks for long-term gains rather than short-term wins" ("In Conclusion").

The new carriers lean towards Africa. Seven of the twelve carriers that launched Cape Town services since 2014 fly to African points, and the largest by seats are Airlink and Ethiopian Airlines (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "The Capetown Market").

Table 2.3. Twelve carriers have launched Cape Town services since 2014, seven of them to African points.

Carrier	Route	2026 seats
Airlink	Various regional points	441,602
Ethiopian Airlines	Addis Ababa	437,430
Turkish Airlines	Istanbul	240,200
United Airlines	Newark and Washington	172,190
Kenya Airways	Nairobi	127,138
Delta Air Lines	Atlanta	110,612
Norse Atlantic UK	London Gatwick	103,428
LATAM Airlines Group	São Paulo	47,084
Air Tanzania	Dar es Salaam and Victoria Falls	37,716
Safair	Windhoek	32,130
Proflight Zambia	Livingstone	14,600
Eswatini Air	Manzini	3,700

Source: MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "The Capetown Market" (carriers launched since 2014, 2026 scheduled seats).

2. The network runs through hubs, and none of it reaches Asia. The seven largest international markets are all hubs, with 2.7 million seats in 2026 against 2.0 million in 2019 (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "The Capetown Market"). Western Europe holds 38% of international capacity, the Middle East 23%, Southern Africa 17%, Eastern Africa 14% and North America 6% ("The Capetown Market").

Most passengers on those hub routes are connecting. Emirates' connecting share is "above 80% annually" and Qatar Airways' nine in ten (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "Seasonality"). MIDAS records "the absence of any direct capacity to any of the Asian markets", and the Diagnostic counts one airline serving Cape Town from Asia against ten from Africa ("The Capetown Market"; Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p35).

3. The routes that exist are full. Eleven of the 27 international routes in the load table ran above 80% in the year to November 2025, led by Newark at 88.6%, Atlanta at 84.3% and Frankfurt and London Heathrow at 83.0% (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "Seasonality"). Sixteen ran at 75% or more, the count the agreed structure attributes to the 80% line (computed from the same table).

The printed network total is 76.0% on 3,816,797 seats, though the 27 listed rows sum to 75.0% (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "Seasonality", computed). Cape Town's 79% average load factor is the joint highest of South Africa's five largest airports, with Lanseria, against about 70% nationally, 75% for Africa and 84% globally ("The South African Market").



Figure 2.3. Eleven of Cape Town's 27 international routes ran above 80% in the year to November 2025, and sixteen at 75% or more.

Source: MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "Seasonality" (international route load-factor table: estimated bookings divided by capacity, bookings for the twelve months to November 2025). Routes above 80% highlighted; the eleven routes below 75% are not shown.

4. Airlines raise fares before they add seats. MIDAS expects that "rather than increase capacity carriers will seek to increase revenues via higher selling fares rather than add new services", which "will frustrate that desire for increased visitors" (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "In Conclusion"). The report carries no fare data, so the claim rests on the author's judgement of airline behaviour.

5. Winter seats are withdrawn. June carried 6.4% of Cape Town's 2025 international seats and December 10.8%, with May, July, August and September at 6.9% each (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "Seasonality"). Connecting traffic is "especially critical in the low season" ("Executive Summary"), which ties the winter schedule to the hub carriers' own priorities.

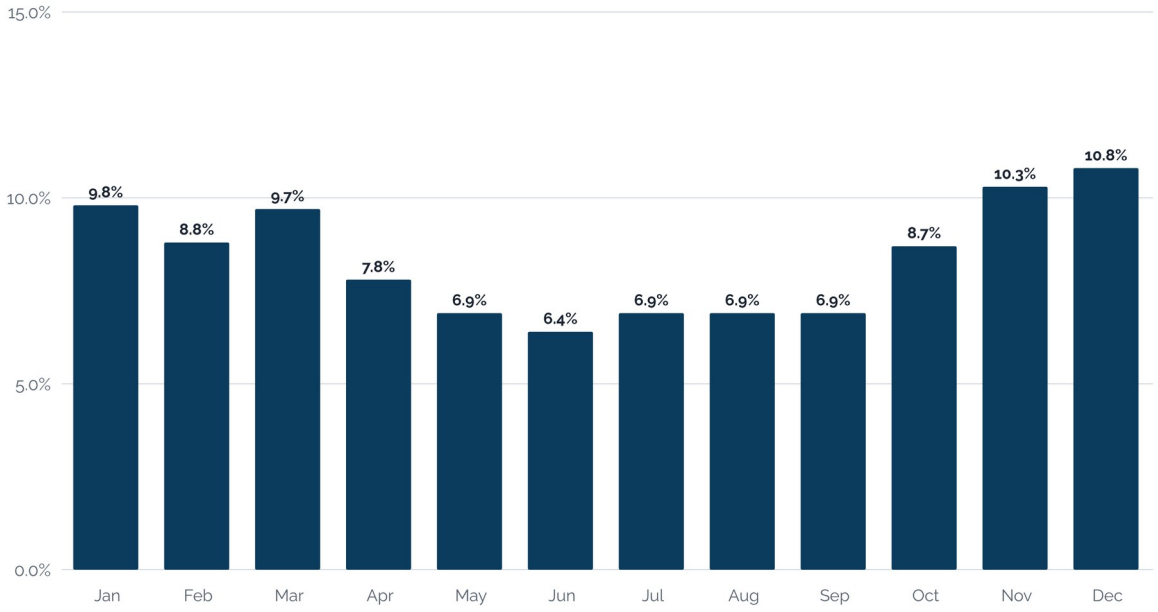


Figure 2.4. Airlines schedule 10.8% of Cape Town's annual international seats in December and 6.4% in June.

Source: MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "Seasonality" (Capetown international capacity by month, 2025, printed data labels).

6. Regional routes run full and can take more capacity. Luanda ran at 86.2% and 83.4% on its two airports, Maputo 83.3%, Gaborone 82.3%, Mauritius 81.8% and Harare 81.3%, and MIDAS names all five markets for further capacity (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "Seasonality"). Domestically, Cape Town to Durban runs at 90.0% and warrants more seats; other domestic routes sit between 70% and 80% ("Seasonality").

7. India and China are long-term, government-led prizes. About 71,000 Indian travellers reached Cape Town indirectly in 2025, half from Mumbai, with Addis Ababa and Dubai carrying 81% of them; direct service is "unlikely before 2030" (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "The Indian Market Opportunity"; "Executive Summary"). China sent about 29,600, and its routes are "frequently an extension of government-to-government relations", with Guangzhou and China Southern the likeliest start ("The Chinese Market Opportunity").

MIDAS recommends early relationships between Wesgro, the Indian carriers and Indian government authorities, and treats China as a long-term investment in awareness and indirect volume before any non-stop service (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "The Indian Market Opportunity"; "The Chinese Market Opportunity"). Australia (61,000 indirect travellers) and Saudi Arabia (137,000 passengers, with Riyadh Air's planned hub) are the next markets on its list ("The Australian Market Opportunity"; "The Saudi Arabian Market Opportunity").

8. The airport, not the airlines, sets the outer limit. Cape Town International's single runway has no parallel taxiway and caps movements at about 30 an hour, and two of the airport's seven parts are already full (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p101, p102). The R6.39bn runway relocation adds about 40% more movements an hour but completes around 2033, and relief across the airport lands from about 2032 (p103).

The alternatives arrive sooner but carry less. George handled 911,000 passengers in 2025, above its design limit, and a R310m terminal expansion doubles it to about 2 million by 2028 (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p104,

p105). Cape Winelands Airport targets first passengers in 2028 on an R8bn phase one but has no firm airline (p106). In the report's words, "the certain fix is the latest, and the earliest big-capacity option is the least certain" (p109).

Table 2.4. Nine findings from the aviation and airport work carry into the hypothesis tree.

Finding	Figure	Source
Route record ahead of peers	17 new mainline international services 2015 to 2025, against Santiago 14, Valencia 12, Calgary 8; 29 international routes in 2026	MIDAS, International Comparisons; Executive Summary
Hub-dependent network	Top seven markets all hubs, 2.7m seats in 2026 (+35% on 2019); Emirates connecting share above 80%	MIDAS, The Capetown Market; Seasonality
No direct Asian capacity	No direct route to any Asian market; one Asian airline against ten African	MIDAS, The Capetown Market; Diagnostic p35
Full routes	11 of 27 routes above 80%; 16 at 75% or more; printed network total 76.0%	MIDAS, Seasonality
Fares before seats	Carriers expected to raise fares rather than add services	MIDAS, In Conclusion
Winter seats withdrawn	June 6.4% and December 10.8% of 2025 international seats	MIDAS, Seasonality
Regional routes full	Luanda 86.2% and 83.4%, Maputo 83.3%, Gaborone 82.3%, Mauritius 81.8%, Harare 81.3%; Durban 90.0%	MIDAS, Seasonality
India and China via hubs	India about 71,000 indirect (2025), direct unlikely before 2030; China about 29,600	MIDAS, Indian and Chinese Market Opportunity
Airport is the ceiling	About 30 movements an hour; relief from about 2032; George to about 2m by 2028	IR p101 to p105

Source: As cited in each row. MIDAS: MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, by section. IR: Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026.

What this means for the tree

Rewords FA07, Win direct routes and add seats on full routes. Eleven routes above 80%, fares before seats and a runway that binds until about 2032 (findings 3, 4 and 8). The structure's "16 of 27 above 80%" is corrected to eleven.

Supports FA02, Create green-season demand with MICE and events. Winter seats fall to 6.4% of the year in June (finding 5).

Rewords FA04, Convert India and China hub traffic. No direct Asian route before 2030; conversion runs through the hubs (findings 2 and 7).

Validates FA05, Increase yield in mature markets. The mature long-haul routes are the fullest (finding 3).

Validates FA06, Build a regional foundation (Africa). Five regional routes above 80% and named for more capacity (finding 6).

Supports FA16, Align institutional stakeholders across all three tiers, and FA19, Lead removal of infrastructure, visa and safety deficits. Chinese routes follow government-to-government agreements and airport capacity sits with ACSA (findings 7 and 8).

2.3 Global benchmarking

The comparator destinations grew faster than the global norm by running institutions, marketing and air access as one system aimed at a single binding constraint.

What was asked

The inception report asked for four to six global comparators aligned to the Western Cape's market profile (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p16). It wanted the strategies and policies behind their growth and the lessons on air access, investment, partnerships and visitor experience that transfer. The agreed report structure assigns this work to SLA Annexure B clauses 1.1.5, 1.1.11 and 3.2.7. [Clause wording to be checked against the signed Annexure B.]

What was done

The Global Benchmarking Report screened 30 destinations against 12 criteria in four groups: market and access, destination and product structure, growth and inclusion, and performance (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p11, p12). Each selected case was then read through one framework covering its demand profile, two proven growth levers and their transferability to the Western Cape (p13).

The final comparator set is the report's six: Chile; Melbourne and Victoria; Valencia; Singapore; Kenya; and Auckland and New Zealand (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p12). This report uses that set. Where a sharper example exists elsewhere, it is cited as a public source and labelled outside the set.

The set moved twice before it settled. The inception report selected Chile, Porto, Vancouver, Melbourne, Valencia and Singapore, and its screen placed Auckland seventh and Kenya eleventh, both marked not selected (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p31, p32). The Diagnostic then recorded that adding Namibia and Kenya "will support a more balanced and regionally grounded benchmark set" (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p62).

The March report kept Kenya, added New Zealand and dropped Porto, Vancouver and Namibia. No document in hand records why, and the change is logged. MIDAS ran its own aviation benchmark against eight secondary airports, summarised in 2.2.

The report sets a global norm against which growth counts as structural. Global arrivals grow 3% to 5% a year under stable conditions, more than 5% marks structural acceleration and 10% or more a structural shift (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p7). Growth counts as structural only when it is "driven by deliberate changes to demand drivers, access conditions or product systems, rather than cyclical recovery or short-term promotion" (p8).

Findings that survived into the tree

1. Five of the six comparators grew well above the norm. Chile grew about 35% between 2023 and 2024, Singapore about 19%, Kenya 12.8% to 14.6%, Valencia 13% to 14% and New Zealand about 12% (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p9). Melbourne's 4.3% is an Australia-wide forecast of average annual growth rather than an actual (p9, p17), and New Zealand's 12% matches its 2025 holiday-arrivals growth; total arrivals grew 5.9% in 2025 (p53).

Table 2.5. Five of the six comparators grew above the 3% to 5% global norm in 2023 to 2024, each through a primary lever of its own.

Destination	Growth 2023 to 2024	Against 2019	Primary lever	System type
Chile	About 35%	About 82% recovered	Gateway-led air concentration	Connectivity-led
Singapore	About 19%	Slightly below; spend recovered	Aviation hub and stopover conversion	Orchestrated experience

Destination	Growth 2023 to 2024	Against 2019	Primary lever	System type
Kenya	12.8% to 14.6%	About 102% recovered	Conservation-led wildlife product	Product-led
Valencia	13% to 14%	124% recovered	Institutionalised quality governance	Governance-led
New Zealand	About 12% (matches 2025 holiday arrivals; total 5.9% in 2025)	90% recovered, higher yield	Demand-led route development	Value-led
Melbourne and Victoria	4.3% (Australia, forecast)	Near full recovery	Event-led demand	Events-led

Source: Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p9 (growth, recovery and levers), p53 (New Zealand arrivals), p17 (Australian forecast) and p61 (system type).

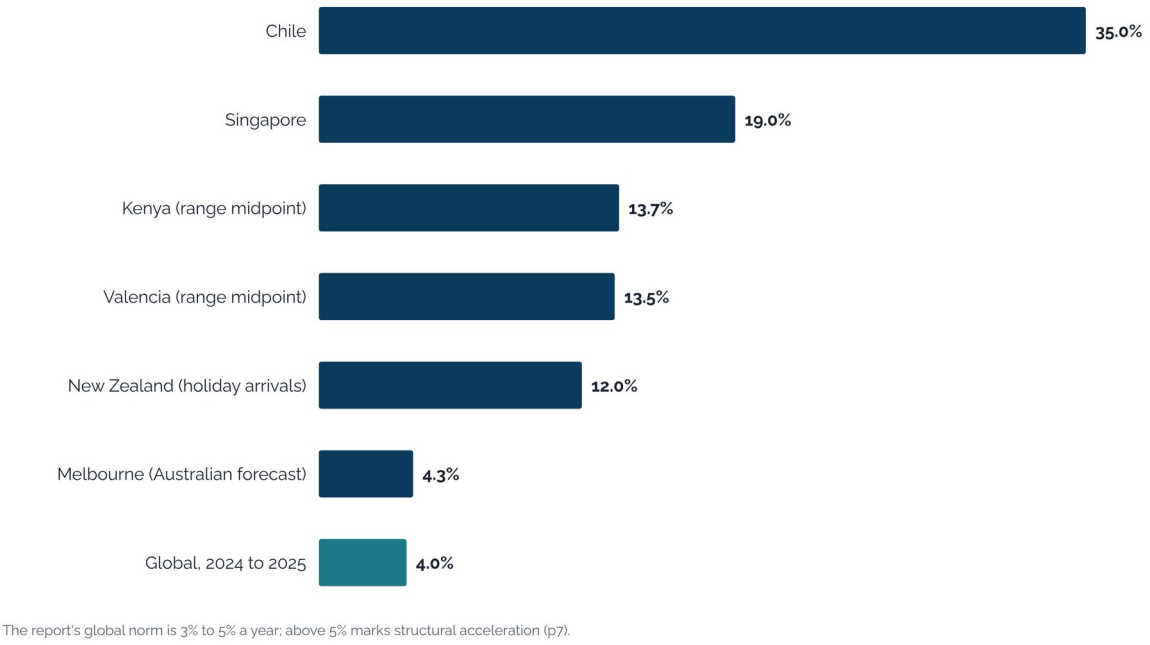


Figure 2.5. Five of the six comparators grew three to nine times the roughly 4% global rate of 2024 to 2025.

Source: Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p7 (global rate, UN Tourism World Tourism Barometer, January 2025) and p9 (comparators). Where the report prints a range, the bar shows its midpoint: Kenya 12.8% to 14.6%, Valencia 13% to 14%.

2. Access comes first, and the state treats it as infrastructure. Santiago handles about 90% to 95% of Chile's 5.2 million international arrivals, and its airport traffic rose from about 16 million passengers in 2010 to more than 26 million in 2019 (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p24, p25). A private concession won in 2015 funded about US$900 million of expansion, under one of the world's most liberal aviation systems built on open-skies agreements (p23, p26).

The report draws the lesson for the Western Cape directly (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p28). It says to "treat air access as core economic infrastructure, not a tourism add-on" and to establish "a permanent, well-funded Public–Private Air Access Fund". It also says to "actively lobby for air service liberalisation and simplified visa regimes" (p28).

3. Marketing money follows routes. New Zealand "shifted from awareness-driven marketing to route accountable demand generation", tying budgets to specific long-haul corridors and designing campaigns around

airline breakeven and shoulder-season loads (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p54). The programme reports more than 16,000 incremental bookings and a return of about NZ$55 million in 2023/24, supported by government-backed early-stage route incentives and data shared between tourism bodies and airlines (p54).

4. Hubs can be converted, not just flown through. Singapore turns transit into visits through its stopover programme, with the tourism board, Changi Airport Group and Singapore Airlines working "under a coordinated strategy" (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p40). It received 13 million international visitors in 2024, 19% more than in 2023, and visitor spend reached $31.3 billion (p39). Kenya positioned Nairobi as East Africa's aviation, diplomatic and business hub, and its main airport now carries 68% of arrivals (p32, p34).

5. Events steady demand and pull air capacity. Victoria curates a portfolio of events that "generate repeat, predictable demand spikes across the year", and Melbourne "uses its event calendar to de-risk and stimulate aviation demand" (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p18, p59). Hotel stock grew 21%, about 5,000 rooms, behind it (p18). The transferable step is "a unified event acquisition and calendar strategy across Wesgro, Convention Bureau, City and Province" (p20).

6. Quality is governed, not encouraged. Valencia adopted a destination-wide quality system across its tourism businesses and placed coordination in "a permanent public–private structure led by Visit València" (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p47). It received 3.5 million international visitors in 2024, 13.9% more than in 2023 and 24.4% above 2019 (p46). The required change is a provincial quality charter, with certification "visible across booking platforms" (p49).

7. The leaders measure value, not arrivals. New Zealand manages regional capacity to protect pricing and recommends that destinations "replace arrival growth with yield-based regional performance metrics" (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p55, p56). Kenya earned about US$1,650 per visitor in 2024 by building conservation and community participation into one governed product system (p32, p33).

8. The system is the lever. The report's synthesis is that "sustained tourism growth is not created by fragmented interventions, but by a coordinated destination system in which governance, demand generation and access reinforce one another" (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p58). Chile's coordination works best "when anchored around a single strategic constraint", which for Chile was long-haul access (p59).

Coordination is hard everywhere. Victoria reports tension between national and state bodies over roles and branding, Valencia struggles to integrate data systems across institutions and Kenya's collaboration between government, industry and financiers is "mixed" (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p16, p31, p45). The Western Cape's constraint has the same shape as Chile's: seats into one gateway airport.

Table 2.6. Each comparator's lesson translates into a change the Western Cape would have to make.

Destination	Lever	Required change for the Western Cape	Page
Chile	Gateway-led air connectivity	Treat air access as core economic infrastructure; a permanent public-private air access fund; lobby for air service liberalisation and simpler visas	p28
New Zealand	Demand-engineered air access	Ring-fence marketing budgets around priority long-haul corridors; an aviation partnership framework; early-stage route support	p56
Melbourne and Victoria	Event-led demand	One event acquisition and calendar strategy across Wesgro, the Convention Bureau, the City and the Province; conference bidding aligned to sector strengths	p20

Destination	Lever	Required change for the Western Cape	Page
Singapore	Hub conversion and quality uplift	Government, aviation, events and industry under shared KPIs; a province-wide quality and standards framework led by Wesgro	p42
Valencia	Governed quality and sector councils	A provincial quality charter, phased by district; certification visible on booking platforms; standing sector councils for wine, MICE, adventure and culture	p49
Kenya	Gateway diversification and conservation-led product	Treat MICE as a system lever; align city, provincial and national actors around a gateway strategy; build conservation and community inclusion into the offer	p35

Source: Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p20, p28, p35, p42, p49, p56 (required change for the Western Cape, condensed).

Table 2.7. Eight benchmark findings carry into the hypothesis tree, each with a named precedent.

Finding	Precedent and figure	Pages
Growth above the norm is designed	Norm 3% to 5% a year; Chile about 35%, Singapore about 19%, Valencia 13% to 14%	p7, p8, p9
Access as infrastructure	Chile: US$900m airport concession (2015); open skies; Santiago 90% to 95% of 5.2m arrivals	p23 to p26
Air access fund	Chile lesson: permanent public-private air access fund; lobby for liberalisation and simpler visas	p28
Route-accountable marketing	New Zealand: 16,000+ incremental bookings; about NZ$55m return, 2023/24	p54
Hub conversion	Singapore: stopover programme; 13m arrivals (+19%) and $31.3bn spend, 2024	p39, p40
Events pull capacity	Melbourne: 5,000 new rooms (+21%); unified event calendar across Wesgro, City and Province	p18, p20
Governed quality	Valencia: destination-wide quality system; 3.5m visitors (+13.9%), 2024	p46, p47
Value metrics	New Zealand: yield-based regional metrics; Kenya: about US$1,650 per visitor	p32, p56

Source: Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, pages as cited.

What this means for the tree

Supplies precedent for FA07, Win direct routes and add seats on full routes, and FA15, Crowd in capital with targeted investment strategies. Chile's airport concession and air access fund; New Zealand's route-tied marketing (findings 2 and 3).

Supplies precedent for FA04, Convert India and China hub traffic. Singapore's stopover conversion and Kenya's hub strategy (finding 4).

Supplies precedent for FA02, Create green-season demand with MICE and events. Melbourne's events-led system and unified calendar (finding 5).

Supplies precedent for FA11, Align visitor experience in-destination, and FA03, Make the whole province findable and bookable. Valencia's governed quality and certification visible on booking platforms (finding 6).

Supplies precedent for FA05, FA12 and FA14. Yield-based metrics, capacity discipline and conservation-led product (finding 7).

Supports FA16, FA17 and FA18. One coordinated system of governance, marketing and access, with shared data between tourism bodies and airlines (findings 3 and 8).

2.4 Stakeholder insights

Collaboration and data sharing are the barriers stakeholders raise most often, and the supply-side constraints they rate most severe.

What was asked

The inception report committed the study to interviews, focus groups and roundtables with key stakeholders, with their insights carried into the final report (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p22). The agreed report structure assigns this work to SLA Annexure B clauses 1.1.6 and 3.2.8. [Clause wording to be checked against the signed Annexure B.]

What was done

Engagement runs in four phases: introduction and framing from January to March 2026, sense-making and validation, strategy socialisation and mobilisation into October (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p4, p17). The March report closes the first phase. It holds insight tables for 16 organisations, from Mossel Bay to the CTICC, carrying 223 insights rated 115 High, 102 Medium and 6 Low (p20 to p46, counted).

The method had four steps: run the sessions, extract insights, map each to the hypothesis tree and aggregate (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p5). The insights are the project team's concise statements, not verbatim quotations. This report therefore attributes them to organisations and quotes them as insight statements.

The record has two gaps. No airline, online travel agent or tour operator sits in the first phase; six such engagements, among them Trip.com, Emirates and SATSA, were proposed for the second (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p16). The outcomes of phases two to four are in no document in hand. [Letsema to supply the phase 2 to 4 engagement record for Appendix A6.]

Findings that survived into the tree

1. Collaboration and data are the most widely shared concerns. Fifteen of the 16 organisations raised industry and government collaboration and fifteen raised policy and data sharing (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p20 to p46, counted). Data sharing also carries the most insights (30) and the most High ratings (16).

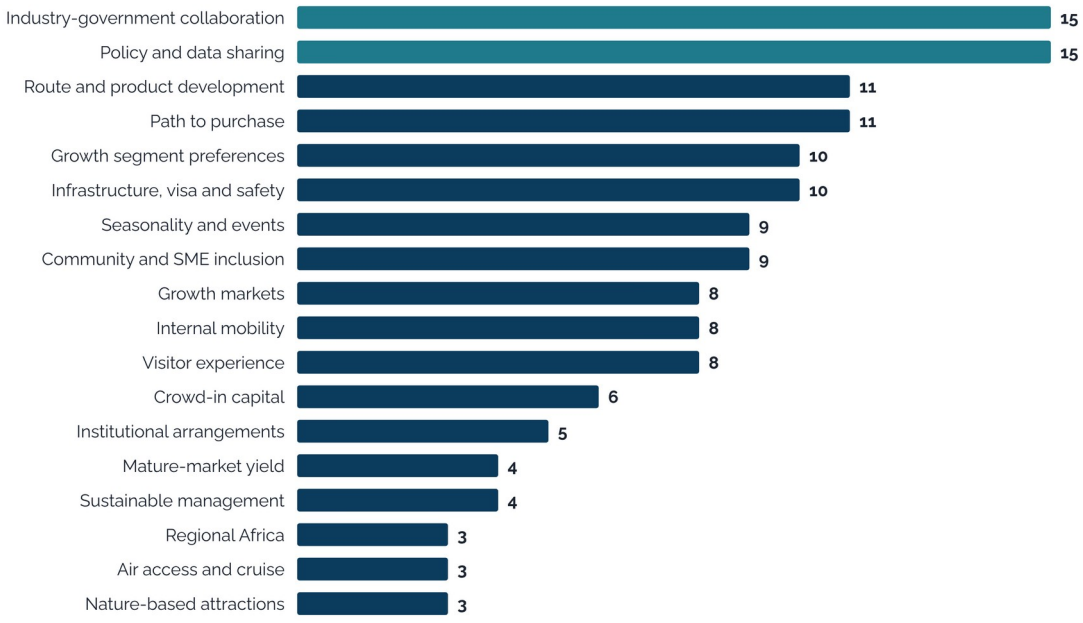


Figure 2.6. Fifteen of 16 organisations raised collaboration and fifteen raised policy and data sharing, more than any other theme.

Source: Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p20 to p46: number of the 16 organisations with at least one insight under each hypothesis-tree element, counted from the appendix tables. The report prints no tally.

The organisations describe the data architecture as "too fragmented, lagged and proxy-based to provide a reliable view of visitor volumes, spend, spread or economic impact at provincial level" (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p13). Platforms for collaboration already exist: FEDHASA points to JAMS, through which tourism associations coordinate with Wesgro, the Western Cape Government and the City of Cape Town (p31).

2. The province cannot yet measure what the strategy targets. The national Department of Tourism reports that "there is no approved official methodology for provincial tourism GDP and jobs estimates", rated High (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p37). Stats SA cites 749 vacancies behind delays to the tourism satellite account and infers provincial flows partly from ports-of-entry data (p30).

3. Supply constraints are rated the most severe. Of the 68 insights under Transform Supply, 44 are rated High, against 23 of 64 under Reshape Demand (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p20 to p46, counted). Weak public transport, congestion and unreliable last-mile access are called "structural barriers to visitor movement within and beyond Cape Town" (p10). Peak queues at the Table Mountain Aerial Cableway run up to three hours up and two hours down (p36).

4. Funding and institutions have weakened. The Department of Economic Development rates destination funding "materially below peer destinations" and reports that tourism institutional capacity "has eroded over the past decade at both provincial and municipal level", both High (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p25). National Treasury Circular 131 has disrupted municipal funding for local tourism bodies, most of which "are not operationally sustainable without municipal funding support" (p25).

Mandates blur at district level. The West Coast District Municipality reports "a mandate disconnect" between district, local municipalities and local tourism organisations that leaves tourism development without a clear

owner (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p39). Fiscal pressure is turning attention to a tourism levy and blended finance (p25, p23).

5. The binding levers sit nationally. The Department of Economic Development reports that "restrictive bilateral air agreements are limiting airlift growth", rated High, and that SA Tourism's institutional weakness constrains international marketing (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p24, p25). Four organisations raised visas, among them the Cableway for India and China and the CTICC for African events (p36, p45). Seven raised safety, which the report calls a barrier across transport, township tourism and international selling (p10).

6. The flagship sites are at capacity and exposed to weather. Boulders is "already near carrying capacity" and summit expansion on Table Mountain is severely limited (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p24, p36). Robben Island loses about R16 million a year to weather-cancelled trips, and CapeNature reports climate-related flooding, fire and heat closing sites (p33, p43).

7. Much product cannot be booked online. CapeNature takes about 70% of its reservations through its call centre rather than its online platform (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p42). The Department of Economic Development rates destination platforms behind international practice in online presence and AI adoption, and the Overberg says its proximity to Cape Town is not packaged before travellers book flights (p24, p26).

8. Some constraints went unraised. No stakeholder named Cape Town International's capacity as a constraint; the airport appears only as a transfer-time reference (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p22, p43). Cruise is raised only by Mossel Bay, where calls rose from four before COVID to 27 a season (p20). The demand-side and airport voices were scheduled for later phases, so their absence here is a gap in the record, not a finding.

The report closes on eight areas for deeper engagement, which frame the questions the later phases were to test (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p14).

Table 2.8. Eight priority areas carry the stakeholder work into its later phases.

Priority area	Question for the next round
Province-wide access, mobility and visitor movement	Which transport bottlenecks cause the most friction for visitor movement?
International access friction: air, visas and onward conversion	Where is the province losing conversion in the international access journey?
Destination readiness, safety and resilience	Which safety issues most damage demand and destination confidence?
Product diversification and spread beyond the Cape Town core	Which barriers stop secondary destinations from scaling?
Inclusive growth and SME and community participation	Why are current support mechanisms not scaling market-ready operators?
Market prioritisation in mature and emerging source markets	How should mature-market yield be balanced against growth-market expansion?
Seasonality, events and demand spread	Which events have the strongest off-peak and regional potential?
Digital conversion, packaging and tourism intelligence	What is the minimum tourism-data architecture needed for better decisions?

Source: Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p14 (one of the four questions listed under each area).

Table 2.9. Eight attributed insights, all rated High, carry the weight of the stakeholder evidence.

Organisation	Insight statement	Page
Dept of Economic Development	Restrictive bilateral air agreements are limiting airlift growth and leave the province less competitive than peer destinations	p24
Dept of Economic Development	Western Cape/Cape Town tourism funding is materially below peer destinations for destination management and destination marketing	p25
Dept of Economic Development	National Treasury Circular 131 has disrupted established municipal funding mechanisms for local tourism bodies	p25
Dept of Tourism	There is no approved official methodology for provincial tourism GDP and jobs estimates	p37
CapeNature	Approximately 70% of reservations come through the call centre rather than the online platform	p42
Robben Island Museum	Weather and climate disruption cost roughly R16 million a year in cancelled trips	p33
West Coast District	A mandate disconnect between the district, local municipalities and LTOs has created unclear ownership for tourism development	p39
Table Mountain Cableway	Peak-period queues of up to three hours up and two hours down detract from the visitor experience	p36

Source: Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, appendix tables, pages as cited. Insights are the project team's statements, attributed to the organisation engaged.

Table 2.10. Eight findings from the stakeholder record carry into the hypothesis tree.

Finding	Figure	Pages
Collaboration and data most widely raised	15 of 16 organisations each; data sharing 30 insights, 16 High	p20 to p46
No provincial jobs or GDP method	No approved methodology; satellite account delayed by 749 vacancies	p30, p37
Supply rated most severe	44 of 68 supply insights High, against 23 of 64 for demand	p20 to p46
Funding and institutions weakened	Funding below peers; capacity eroded; Circular 131 disrupts LTO funding	p25, p39
National levers bind	Bilateral air agreements; visas raised by four organisations; safety by seven	p10, p24, p36, p45
Flagships at capacity	Boulders near carrying capacity; Robben Island about R16m a year lost to weather	p24, p33
Product hard to book	CapeNature about 70% of reservations by call centre	p42
Gaps in the record	No airline, OTA or tour operator in phase one; airport capacity not raised	p16, p22

Source: Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, pages as cited; counts from the appendix tables, p20 to p46.

What this means for the tree

Validates FA17, Strengthen industry and government collaboration, and FA18, Expedite tourism-enabling policy and data sharing. Each raised by 15 of 16 organisations, with existing platforms such as JAMS to build on (findings 1 and 2).

Rewords FA16, Align institutional stakeholders across all three tiers, and supports FA19, Lead removal of infrastructure, visa and safety deficits. Air rights, visas and SA Tourism sit nationally; mandates blur at district level (findings 4 and 5).

Rewords FA14, Manage climate risk and sustainable tourism, and supports FA15, Crowd in capital. Unfunded local tourism bodies and climate losses at flagship sites (findings 4 and 6).

Supports FA03, FA09, FA10 and FA12. Product that cannot be booked online, last-mile access, a narrow product set and flagships at capacity (findings 3, 6 and 7).

Supplies the case for FA20, Develop workforce and service skills, as a question. Skills gaps raised by CapeNature, the West Coast and the Overberg, with no labour analysis behind them (p27, p39, p43).

2.5 Spatial and infrastructure readiness

Tourism readiness falls with every step away from Cape Town, so growth outside the Metro depends on deliberate corridor investment rather than spillover.

The tourism economy and who shares in it

The supply-side evidence in this section and the next starts from the same fact: the tourism economy is large and concentrated. Foreign visitors spent R25.9bn in the province in FY2025 (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p11), and the Cape Metro generates 72.5% of provincial GDPR (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p39).

Little of that spend reaches the communities around the nodes. The 20 communities shortlisted by the inclusion work hold 18.4% of the province's residents (Census 2011) but receive a traced floor of 0.02% to 0.04% of foreign direct spend, about R4m to R10m a year (SME and Community Inclusion Plan, Sep 2026, p5). Section 2.5 sets out where the supply sits; section 2.6 sets out why so little of it is shared.

What was asked

The supply phase was asked to understand spatial infrastructure and readiness for scalable growth through an asset inventory and readiness index, GIS mapping, regional profiles and an investment opportunity framework (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p11, p18). The agreed report structure assigns this work to SLA Annexure B clauses 1.1.2, 1.1.8 and 3.2.4. [Clause wording to be checked against the signed Annexure B.]

What was done

The Infrastructure Report mapped 50,332 tourism assets across the six regions in three layers: attractions, services and enabling infrastructure (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p2, p9, p10). It drew on Wesgro's supply database, SANParks and CapeNature data and open geographic sources (p4). Its premise is that "destination performance is constrained by the weakest layer" (p9).

Each region is scored from 1 to 5 on attractiveness (40%), readiness and capacity (30%) and accessibility (30%) (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p17). The scores "are evidence informed, not purely formula derived", and missing data is not scored as poor performance (p18). The printed overall ratings do not reproduce from the weighted dimension scores, so this report quotes them as printed.

Six touring routes were rated Ready, Developing or Gap on access, accommodation, safety and bookability (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p19). The final report of July 2026 supersedes a June draft. [Dataset limits, including the absence of geography below district level, to be confirmed against the supply dataset notes.]

Findings that survived into the tree

1. Readiness halves between the Metro and the periphery. The Cape Metro rates 4.5 out of 5, the Cape Winelands and the Garden Route 3.4, the Overberg 2.7, the West Coast 2.5 and the Central Karoo 1.9 (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p28, p41, p52, p63, p74, p85). The report's summary is blunt: infrastructure is "eroding rapidly with distance from Cape Town, weakening the visitor experience" (p5).

Accessibility falls fastest (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p88 to p90). On attractions it scores 4.7 in the Metro, 3.3 in the Winelands and 3.0 on the Garden Route. It drops to 2.0 in the Overberg, 1.7 on the West Coast and 1.0 in the Central Karoo; on transport the Metro scores 5.0. "The further from Cape Town, the faster the infrastructure falls away" (p90).

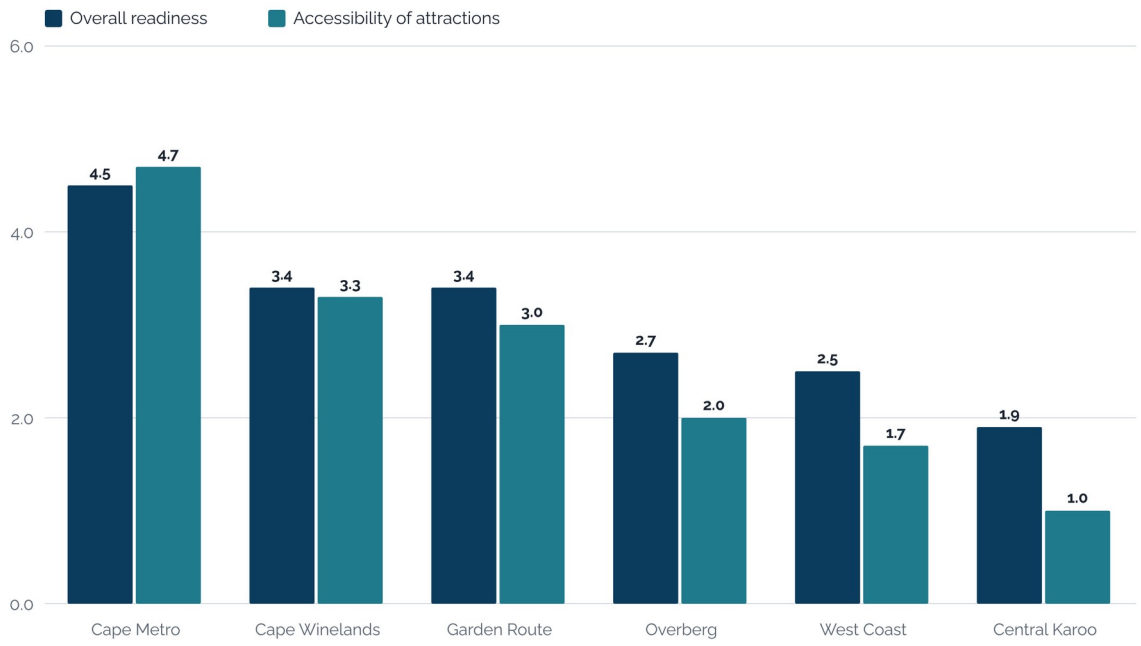


Figure 2.7. Overall readiness and accessibility both fall with each step away from the Cape Metro.

Source: Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026: overall ratings p28, p41, p52, p63, p74, p85; accessibility of attractions p88. Scale 1 (very weak) to 5 (leading). Districts ordered from the Metro outward.

2. Cape Town is the gateway and the dispersal point. The Metro holds 20,281 of the 50,332 assets, 40.3%, and five of the province's six highest-volume attractions (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p23, p88). It is the only region with an international airport and rapid transit (p90). The report concludes that "dispersal needs deliberate corridor investment, not organic spillover from Cape Town" (p5).

Table 2.11. Each district has a distinct strength, and the Metro holds two in every five of the province's tourism assets.

District	Assets	Share	Strength	Weakness
Cape Metro	20,281	40.3%	Five of the six highest-volume attractions; the only international airport and rapid transit	Peak congestion at flagship sites; rail unusable for tourism
Garden Route	9,875	19.6%	Second-largest accommodation stock; a regional airport with direct flights	300km of coastline fragments the route; no inter-town shuttle
Cape Winelands	7,730	15.4%	Largest commercial and leisure base, anchored by 200-plus wine estates	Wine dominates; adventure and heritage under-promoted
Overberg	6,176	12.3%	Whale coast; the only market where demand and pricing peak in winter	Public transport effectively absent; interpretation gaps
West Coast	4,752	9.4%	Highest natural-asset attractiveness; accessible pricing	Short wildflower season; dining in a handful of nodes
Central Karoo	1,518	3.0%	Niche assets of the highest uniqueness; dark-sky astro-tourism	A service desert outside Prince Albert and Beaufort West

Source: Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026: asset counts p23, p34, p45, p56, p67, p78 (the Winelands gauge misprints 40.3%; 7,730 of 50,332 is 15.4%); strengths and weaknesses p88 to p90.

3. Beyond the Metro and the Garden Route the visitor drives. Public transport is "effectively absent" on the West Coast and in the Overberg, the Winelands have no transit between estates or valleys, and every accessibility measure in the Central Karoo "sits at the floor" (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p49, p90). Metro rail is "functionally unusable for tourism" (p90).

4. Strong assets sit in cold zones. The West Coast has the province's highest natural-asset attractiveness and the Central Karoo its most unique niche assets, yet both score lowest on readiness (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p88). Inland areas north of the N2 on the Garden Route are tourism-inactive, and industrial belts in the Metro show "zero tourism conversion" despite nearby attractions (p24, p35).

5. The mid-market is missing. Mid-market accommodation "is effectively absent outside Stellenbosch" in the Winelands, where a "luxury-skewed product mix excludes mid-market and family segments" (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p47, p53). Accommodation is thin beyond Langebaan and Paternoster on the West Coast and thin at international grade along Route 62 (p62, p84). The report gives no bed count for the gap.

6. Bookability fails first in the regions. About 40% or more of the Metro's smaller operators lack online booking (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p32). Route 62 has the lowest online bookability of the six routes, and the West Coast route rates Gap on digital distribution and payments (p62, p84, p87).

Table 2.12. Only the Cape Peninsula route is rated ready for international visitors, and bookability or accommodation is the weak point on the rest.

Route	From Cape Town	Access	Accommodation	Safety	Bookability	Overall
Cape Peninsula	0 km	Ready	Ready	Developing	Ready	Ready
Cape Winelands	50 km	Ready	Ready	Developing	Ready	Developing
Whale Coast and Overberg	120 km	Developing	Developing	Developing	Developing	Developing
West Coast and Cederberg	120 km	Developing	Gap	Ready	Gap	Emerging

Route	From Cape Town	Access	Accommodation	Safety	Bookability	Overall
Route 62 and Klein Karoo	160 km	Developing	Developing	Developing	Gap	Developing
Garden Route	385 km	Ready	Ready	Developing	Ready	Developing

Source: Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p29, p30, p39, p40, p50, p51, p61, p62, p72, p73, p83, p84.

7. The flagships are full in season. Table Mountain Aerial Cableway queues run two to three hours at peak, Chapman's Peak suffers disruptions and the December to January peak "overwhelms transport and accommodation capacity" (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p28, p32). Cape Point and township attractions, by contrast, are underused (p24).

8. Committed capital closes the air gaps, not the regional ones. The Metro's pipeline exceeds R30bn, led by ACSA's R11.3bn airport overhaul and the R20bn V&A Granger Bay expansion, and George's R310m terminal doubles capacity by 2028 (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p32, p43). Last-mile transit, small-operator bookability and township product remain unfunded in the Metro, as do inter-node transport and winter product on the Garden Route (p32, p43).

Port spending is not going to cruise. Cape Town's single berth runs at about 40% of a season capacity of 150 or more calls, with 83 calls and R1.79bn of impact in 2024/25 (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p110). Saldanha's R4bn upgrade is for iron ore, and the report's advice is to grow cruise "through product and marketing, not capital works" (p112).

Table 2.13. Cape Town's cruise berth has spare capacity, Mossel Bay is ready for day stops and Saldanha Bay is a watching brief.

Port	Activity	Constraint	Stance
Cape Town	83 calls and about 127,000 passengers in 2024/25, about 40% of a season capacity of 150 or more calls; R1.79bn impact	300m ship-length limit and the South-Easter wind; no shore power	Protect
Mossel Bay	21 calls and about 13,000 passengers; R22m passenger facility opened November 2025	No cruise quay; ships anchor and tender; small and mid-sized ships only	Back now
Saldanha Bay	3 trial calls	Shares the ore terminal; no cruise berth or passenger facility	Watch

Source: Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p110 to p112.

Table 2.14. Each region carries a remaining gap that no committed investment closes.

Region	Rating	Committed investment	Gap that remains open
Cape Metro	4.5	R11.3bn airport overhaul; R20bn V&A Granger Bay; R3.3bn MyCiTi Phase 2	Last-mile transit to Chapman's Peak, Constantia and Cape Point; small-operator online booking; township product
Cape Winelands	3.4	R8bn Cape Winelands Airport phase one, by 2028; R16bn to R20bn wider precinct	No transit inside the wine triangle; non-wine product; pricing for domestic visitors
Garden Route	3.4	R310m George terminal, by 2028; R9.4m landing-system upgrade	No international carrier; winter trough; transport between towns
Overberg	2.7	R81.7m Agulhas lighthouse precinct; R17m Malgas road	Accommodation towards De Hoop; bookability east of Hermanus; year-round product
West Coast	2.5	R693m Malmesbury bypass (complete); R4bn Saldanha port upgrade, iron ore	Accommodation depth; digital payments; no airport

Region	Rating	Committed investment	Gap that remains open
Central Karoo and Route 62	1.9	R62 reconstruction under way; rural broadband to 2026	Accommodation depth; emergency support; no airport

Source: Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026: ratings p28, p41, p52, p63, p74, p85; gaps and investments p32, p43, p54, p65, p76, p87.

Table 2.15. Eight findings from the spatial and infrastructure work carry into the hypothesis tree.

Finding	Figure	Pages
Readiness falls with distance	Metro 4.5; Winelands and Garden Route 3.4; Overberg 2.7; West Coast 2.5; Central Karoo 1.9	p28 to p85
Accessibility decays	4.7 in the Metro to 1.0 in the Central Karoo (attractions); 5.0 to 1.0 (transport)	p88 to p90
Cape Town is the gateway	20,281 of 50,332 assets (40.3%); only international airport and rapid transit	p23, p90
Car-only beyond Metro and Garden Route	Public transport effectively absent in the West Coast and Overberg	p90
Mid-market missing	Mid-market accommodation effectively absent outside Stellenbosch	p47, p53
Bookability weakest in the regions	About 40% or more of smaller Metro operators lack online booking; Route 62 lowest	p32, p87
Flagships full at peak	Cableway queues of two to three hours; Dec to Jan peak overwhelms capacity	p28, p32
Capital closes air gaps only	Metro pipeline R30bn or more; George R310m by 2028; cruise berth at about 40%	p32, p43, p110

Source: Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, pages as cited.

What this means for the tree

Validates FA09, Accelerate tourism-enabling internal mobility. Accessibility decays from 4.7 to 1.0 and public transport is absent beyond the Metro and the Garden Route (findings 1 and 3).

Validates FA10, Support diversified route and product development, and FA11, Align visitor experience in-destination. Strong assets in cold zones and a missing mid-market (findings 4 and 5).

Validates FA12, Balance impact on nature-based attractions. Flagships full at peak while alternatives are underused (finding 7).

Supports FA03, Make the whole province findable and bookable. Bookability fails first in the regions (finding 6).

Supports FA07, FA08 and FA15. Airport capital is committed; cruise needs product, not berths; regional gaps have no committed capital (finding 8).

2.6 SME and community inclusion

Organisation, not distance, keeps tourism spend out of the province's townships and rural settlements: 93 of 107 sit within 45 minutes of a tourism node.

Section 2.5 opened with the scale of the gap: the 20 shortlisted communities hold 18.4% of residents (Census 2011) and receive a traced floor of 0.02% to 0.04% of foreign direct spend (SME and Community Inclusion Plan, Sep 2026, p5). This section explains why.

What was asked

The inception report asked for a framework to bring SMMEs and communities into tourism, built from value-chain analysis, a typology of barriers, evaluation of global models and an inclusion blueprint (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p19). The agreed report structure assigns this work to SLA Annexure B clauses 1.1.3, 1.1.9 and 3.2.5. [Clause wording to be checked against the signed Annexure B.]

What was done

The SME and Community Inclusion Plan set out "to identify which township and rural communities are missing out on tourism income, to understand why and identify practical routes to stimulate development" (SME and Community Inclusion Plan, Sep 2026, p3). It defines inclusion by where the activity sits: a tour, a meal, a bed or a market inside the community counts; a resident commuting to a hotel job in town does not (p4).

The long-list takes every Census sub-place cluster of 1,500 people or more with official unemployment of 25% or more, plus named mission, fishing and farm settlements (SME and Community Inclusion Plan, Sep 2026, p14). That gives 107 communities holding 2.81 million people in 2011, 48% of the province (p16). Five weighted criteria (need, tourism potential, proximity, readiness and access) produced a shortlist of 20, five in the Cape Metro and three in each district (p14, p16).

The evidence joins Census 2011 sub-places to an OpenStreetMap asset layer extracted in September 2026, with road travel times and municipal plans (SME and Community Inclusion Plan, Sep 2026, p15, p16). Need rests on Census 2011 because Census 2022 is not published below ward level and asked no income question (p15). Five benchmark cases, from Rio de Janeiro to Kliptown, test what lasted (p7 to p11).

Findings that survived into the tree

1. The communities hold people, not spend. The 20 shortlisted communities hold 18.4% of Western Cape residents and 15.4% of employed residents (Census 2011) but receive 0.02% to 0.04% of foreign direct spend, about R4m to R10m a year on the documented floor (SME and Community Inclusion Plan, Sep 2026, p5). Capturing 1% of FY2025 foreign direct spend would bring R259m a year (p5).

2. Distance is not the barrier. Of the 107 long-listed communities, 93 lie within 45 minutes of one of 35 tourism nodes or three corridors (SME and Community Inclusion Plan, Sep 2026, p16). Langa is 12 minutes from Cape Town International and Zwelihle seven from Hermanus (p18). Distance is the binding constraint in none of the 20 (p30).

3. Organisation is. Organisation is the binding constraint in 11 of the 20, ten have no identified active tourism body and nine show no benefit visible to residents (SME and Community Inclusion Plan, Sep 2026, p28, p30). Product often exists without a seller: Langa's walk sells on global platforms at ratings above 4.8, yet city firms sell most of the 23 Langa walks on Viator (p20, p28).

The same pattern repeats. Zwelihle's four resident guides sell by phone with no shared booking channel, and the Mitchells Plain festival drew 27,800 visitors in November 2025 with no local operator or LTO behind it (SME and Community Inclusion Plan, Sep 2026, p22, p34). The communities cannot yet be found or booked on the channels visitors use.

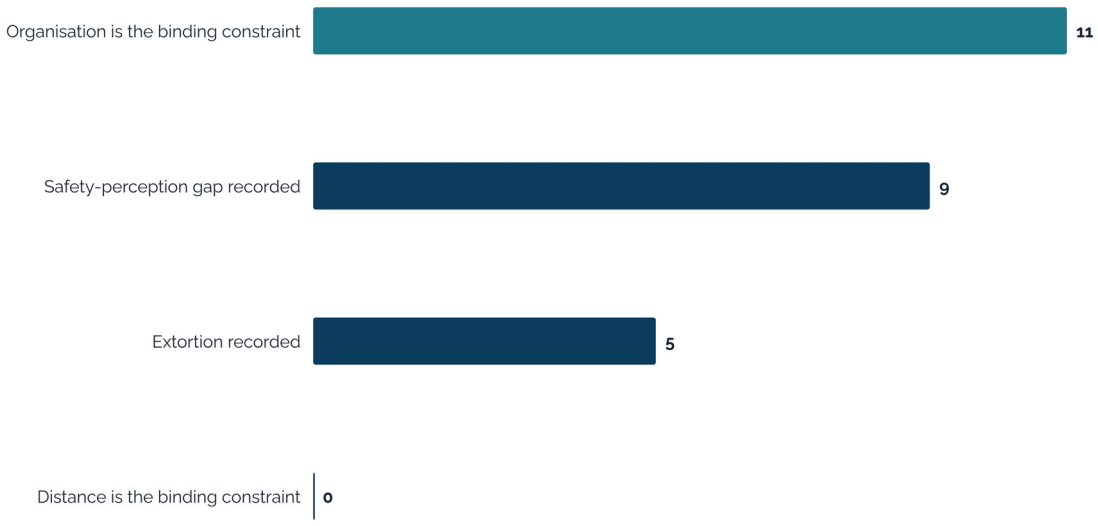


Figure 2.8. Organisation binds in 11 of the 20 shortlisted communities and distance in none.

Source: SME and Community Inclusion Plan, Sep 2026, p30 (constraint tally across the 20 shortlisted communities).

4. Safety is the second gate. Nine of the 20 record a safety-perception gap and five record extortion (SME and Community Inclusion Plan, Sep 2026, p30). The plan treats safety as a launch requirement in its own right: "tourism activity alone cannot resolve crime or extortion" (p35).

5. The benchmarks point to one order. The cases converge on "a seller with a stake, a safe and workable visit, product that keeps spend in the community, then exposure" (SME and Community Inclusion Plan, Sep 2026, p12). In Rio, resident guides kept selling after the programme that launched them ended; local selling mechanisms lasted where assets and training without a route to market did not (p7, p30).

Capital first fails. Kliptown received a first allocation of R436 million and was projected to draw almost 200,000 international visitors a year, but its museum drew about 4,000 visitors a year by 2017 (SME and Community Inclusion Plan, Sep 2026, p11). Costa Rica's community network turned over more than USD 800,000 in 2013 and dissolved after donor support ended (p10).

Table 2.16. Five benchmark cases show that sellers outlast programmes and that capital without an operator earns nothing.

Case	What happened	Lesson	Page
Rio de Janeiro, Santa Marta	About 20 resident guides ran the tours by 2015 and outside jeep firms had left	Access and safety are preconditions, not product; resident sellers outlast programmes	p7
Medellín, Comuna 13	1.98 million visitors in 2025, 52% international; about 300 professional guides	Mobility built for residents became the stage; carrying-capacity limits came late	p8
Vilakazi Street, Soweto	Ten restaurants employ more than 800 people	Public-realm works amplify existing assets; benefits concentrate on street-front owners	p9
Costa Rica community network	Turnover above USD 800,000 in 2013; dissolved at the end of 2018	A selling entity is the engine and must survive donor exit	p10

Case	What happened	Lesson	Page
Kliptown, Soweto	R436 million allocated; about 4,000 museum visitors a year by 2017	Capital built before an operator yields no operating income	p11

Source: SME and Community Inclusion Plan, Sep 2026, p7 to p11.

6. Each archetype needs its own first move. Communities near a node with product already in place need a seller and a slot in the node's itineraries (SME and Community Inclusion Plan, Sep 2026, p15). Those near a node with nothing inside need one anchor asset, but only after a seller is in place. Remote communities need access first or, where nothing sits inside, procurement and skills before any asset (p15).

Table 2.17. Most long-listed communities sit near a node with something already worth visiting, and each archetype carries its own response.

Archetype	Long-list	Shortlist	First response
Near a node, assets underused	49	11	Integrate: itinerary slots, procurement and events; organise sellers
Near a node, no assets	43	6	Create one anchor asset under a covenant, then integrate; a seller comes first
Remote, assets underused	7	2	Open access and place the asset on a route product the LTO already sells
Remote, no assets	8	1	Procurement and skills first; an asset only once a route product exists

Source: SME and Community Inclusion Plan, Sep 2026, p15 and p17 (long-list and shortlist counts; p4 prints 48 and 8 for the two assets-underused rows), p15 (responses).

7. The model is a seller, a link to demand and a set of gates. The plan's core model is a functioning selling capability, a connection to demand the node already has and launch gates for safety, access and a viable operating model (SME and Community Inclusion Plan, Sep 2026, p32). It proposes a pilot in two or three of six profiled communities, scaled only once bookings, local spend, delivery and safety meet thresholds agreed before launch (p32).

The first deliverable is deliberately small: "one live booking route, published operating dates, a named customer contact and a simple record of bookings and local revenue" (SME and Community Inclusion Plan, Sep 2026, p33). Most of the illustrative first moves carry no dedicated budget line (p36). Roles and funding are set out in Chapter 4.

8. Nobody counts tourism jobs inside the communities. No profile counts tourism employment inside a community boundary; the plan gives node-side figures instead, such as about 4,700 formal Town Centre jobs for 82,393 employed Mitchells Plain residents (SME and Community Inclusion Plan, Sep 2026, p22). Need rests on fifteen-year-old Census data (p15).

Table 2.18. The 20 shortlisted communities span every region and sit between 1 and 111 minutes from their nearest node.

Region	Community	Type	Score	Minutes to node	Binding constraint
Cape Metro	Langa	N-A	3.00	12 to CTIA	Organisation
Cape Metro	Khayelitsha	N-A	3.00	15 to CTIA	Organisation
Cape Metro	Gugulethu	N-A	2.80	8 to CTIA	Attraction
Cape Metro	Mitchells Plain	N-A	2.35	16 to CTIA	Organisation
Cape Metro	Atlantis	R-A	2.20	26 to Darling	Organisation
Cape Winelands	Kayamandi	N-0	2.55	8 to Stellenbosch	Safety

Region	Community	Type	Score	Minutes to node	Binding constraint
Cape Winelands	Mbekweni	N-0	2.40	10 to Paarl	Attraction
Cape Winelands	Nkqubela	N-0	1.90	22 to the R62	Attraction
Overberg	Genadendal	N-A	2.45	11 to Greyton	Organisation
Overberg	Zwelihle	N-A	2.05	7 to Hermanus	Organisation
Overberg	Kassiesbaai	N-A	2.05	1 to Arniston	Organisation
Garden Route	Knysna northern townships	N-0	2.60	9 to Knysna	Market link
Garden Route	Thembalethu	N-0	2.30	11 to George	Attraction
Garden Route	De Rust	N-A	2.30	42 to the R62	Infrastructure
West Coast	Laingville	N-A	2.10	4 to St Helena Bay	Organisation
West Coast	Doringbaai	R-0	2.00	111 to Clanwilliam	Organisation
West Coast	Elands Bay	R-A	1.85	87 to Clanwilliam	Organisation
Central Karoo	Laingsburg (Bergsig)	N-A	2.35	22 to Matjiesfontein	Attraction
Central Karoo	Kwa-Mandlenkosi	N-0	2.20	6 to Beaufort West	Organisation
Central Karoo	Prince Albert North	N-A	1.80	4 to Prince Albert	Attraction

Source: SME and Community Inclusion Plan, Sep 2026, p18 (shortlist, composite score, free-flow minutes) and p53 to p58 (binding constraint). Archetypes abbreviated: N = near a node (45 minutes or less); R = remote; A = assets underused; 0 = no community-based product.

Table 2.19. Eight findings from the inclusion work carry into the hypothesis tree.

Finding	Figure	Pages
Communities hold people, not spend	18.4% of residents (Census 2011); 0.02% to 0.04% of foreign direct spend traced (floor); R4m to R10m a year	p5
Capture potential	1% of FY2025 foreign direct spend is R259m a year	p5
Distance is not the barrier	93 of 107 within 45 minutes of a node or corridor; distance binds in 0 of 20	p16, p30
Organisation is	Binds in 11 of 20; 10 have no active tourism body	p28, p30
Safety is the second gate	Safety-perception gap in 9 of 20; extortion in 5	p30
Sellers last; capital first fails	Kliptown: R436m allocated, about 4,000 museum visitors a year by 2017	p11, p12
Pilot before scale	Two or three of six profiled communities; scale only after thresholds are met	p32
No jobs counted inside	No profile counts tourism jobs inside a community boundary	p22, p40

Source: SME and Community Inclusion Plan, Sep 2026, pages as cited.

What this means for the tree

Refines FA13, Embed local destination bodies for community inclusion. The binding constraint is a seller with a stake, then a safe way in, then demand pulled from the adjacent node (findings 2, 3, 5 and 7).

Supports FA03, Make the whole province findable and bookable. Community product sells by phone or through city operators (finding 3).

Supports FA10, Support diversified route and product development, and FA15, Crowd in capital. Assets follow sellers and route products, not the reverse (findings 5 and 6).

Supports FA19, Lead removal of infrastructure, visa and safety deficits. Safety and extortion gate activation in up to nine communities (finding 4).

Supports FA20, Develop workforce and service skills, and FA18, Expedite tourism-enabling policy and data sharing. No count of tourism jobs inside the communities; need rests on Census 2011 (finding 8).

Findings and recommendations

3.1 Pillar 1: Reshape demand

Demand is not what holds Pillar 1 back; conversion is. The province is known in its mature markets, under-sold in its growth markets and hard to book outside its core.

The December tree gave the pillar one objective: break through the market, seasonality and spread ceilings by reshaping the brand toward new traveller segments (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p64). The evidence confirmed all three ceilings.

- **Markets.** Five markets supplied 63% of overseas arrivals in 2025, and the UK, Germany and the USA supplied 52% between them (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p13).
- **Seasons.** June held 6.4% of the year's international seats at Cape Town International in 2025, against 10.8% in December (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, Seasonality).
- **Spread.** Most rural properties have no OTA presence and are invisible to the market (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p95).

What changed between December and October is the diagnosis. The Market Assessment counts about 97 million high-value travellers in 34 markets with an interest in South Africa, of whom about 1.4 million convert into arrivals (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p41). The Diagnostic had already named the constraint as conversion and access, not only awareness (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p30). Three of the six entries were reworded toward conversion: green-season seats, bookable product and hub traffic already in the air.

Pillar 1 carries most of the base case. Between 2025 and 2035 the base case adds 676,949 arrivals (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p20 to p23). The four hub markets supply 206,584, the mature markets 178,780, the acceleration markets 175,818, regional Africa 110,298 and the strategic group 5,469. None of it lands without seats, so the air access entry in Pillar 2 runs beside this pillar from the first phase.

Table 3.1. Pillar 1 holds six focus areas: three carried through as Validated and three were reworded toward conversion.

Focus area	Disposition	What the evidence showed	Initiative
1 Respond to growth segment traveller preferences	Validated	Four segments with named home markets; the province scores 3.7 to 4.6 out of 5 on its ability to win them	I1
2 Create green-season demand with MICE and events	Reworded	June holds 6.4% of the year's seats; international meetings cluster from May to November	I2
3 Make the whole province findable and bookable	Reworded	The outer routes and every shortlisted community fall short on online bookability	I3
4 Convert India and China hub traffic	Reworded	About 101,000 travellers a year already fly in through Dubai, Doha and Addis Ababa	I4
5 Increase yield in mature markets	Validated	Five mature long-haul routes run above 80% load, and carriers on full routes raise fares before seats	I1
6 Build a regional foundation (Africa)	Validated	Regional routes run above 80% load; Nigerian and Ghanaian visitors spend R31,000 and R27,700 each	I5

Source: Chapter 3 entries 1 to 6. Dispositions as recorded at the 14 October 2026 review [Summary of Findings, 14 Oct 2026, pp15 to 16; deck page reference to be confirmed].

3.1.1 Traveller, brand and proposition

The first theme is about whom the Western Cape sells to, when and how. It holds three focus areas: the segments, the green season and the bookability of the province. The theme name carries through from December unchanged.

THEME 1.1 · TRAVELLER, BRAND AND PROPOSITION · FOCUS AREA 1

Respond to growth segment traveller preferences

Four traveller segments, each concentrated in named home markets, give Wesgro a sharper target than country alone, and the province scores 3.7 to 4.6 out of 5 on its ability to win them.

Hypothesis and disposition

December 2025. Respond to Growth Segment Traveller Preferences (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p64). The wording is unchanged in every reprint of the tree.

October 2026: Validated. Four segments were confirmed against markets of high incidence. The Skift segmentation of March 2026 drove the disposition, and the Market Assessment carried it into the demand work.

Evidence

The segmentation rests on a May 2025 survey of more than 25,000 outbound travellers in 17 priority markets (Skift Segmentation Analysis, Mar 2026, Research Methodology).

Table 3.2. Four segments are sized, scored and tied to home markets, and the highest-yield segment is the smallest.

Finding	Figure	Source
Four segments are sized	Curious Explorers about 30m, Creative Connectors about 25m, Discerning Connoisseurs about 19m and Reflective Adventurers about 23m addressable long-haul travellers across 34 markets	Skift, Executive Summary; MA p43
The province can win them	Ability-to-win 4.6, 4.1, 4.0 and 3.7 out of 5.0, scored on product fit, brand fit, competition and ease of air access	Skift, Ability-to-Win Assessment
Each segment has home markets	Curious Explorers are 30% of UK and US travellers; Reflective Adventurers 33% of German; Creative Connectors 32% of Indian; Discerning Connoisseurs 40% of UAE	Skift, Segment Incidence by Market; MA p43
The smallest segment yields most	Discerning Connoisseurs spend $8,500 to $14,000 a long-haul trip, three to four times the other segments	Skift, segment 03; MA p51
Each segment books differently	Creative Connectors book 42% through OTAs; Discerning Connoisseurs 42% through luxury travel advisors and 6% through OTAs	Skift, Travel Behaviour and Spend; MA p49, p52
Conversion is the gap	About 97 million addressable travellers across 34 markets; about 1.4 million convert into arrivals	MA p41

Source: Skift Segmentation Analysis, Mar 2026 (working analysis, cited by section); Market Assessment Report, May 2026 (MA). Trip spend in the currency printed, which the documents do not name. The 1.4 million carries no year or source line.

Two limits qualify the word confirmed. The segmentation leaves out the domestic market and seven African markets, Nigeria, Kenya and Ghana among them, and Skift calls its findings directional rather than definitive (Skift Segmentation Analysis, Mar 2026, Research Methodology and Disclaimer). No Western Cape validation exists yet.

Stakeholders also name segments outside the four: medical tourism, township culture, eco-adventure and international MICE (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p34, p35, p42, p45). These are product interests that cut across the segments, and the report treats them that way rather than as a fifth segment.

Recommendation

Wesgro should market by segment within market, not by market alone, and judge results by value as well as volume. The UK and Germany anchor the near term with a combined pool of about 12.5 million, and the USA is the largest single pool outside China (Skift Segmentation Analysis, Mar 2026, Strategic Implications). The Department of Economic Development asks for the same shift, toward a value and spend lens over arrivals (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p24).

Who acts	Action	Lead and partners
Wesgro	Set segment targets inside each priority market: Curious Explorers in the UK and USA, Reflective Adventurers in Germany, Creative Connectors in India, Discerning Connoisseurs in the UAE	Destination Marketing; Research
Wesgro	Move spend from broad awareness to trade-led conversion through each segment's own channels, from luxury advisors to mobile-first OTAs	Destination Marketing; trade and OTA partners
Wesgro	Commission destination-specific research to validate the segments, extend it to the domestic and African markets and build the segments into brand tracking	Research
Partners	Develop segment-matched product: heritage and township experiences, creative districts, private-access wine and food, and a certified wellness and trail network	Product owners; CapeNature; SANParks; LTOs
National	Agree one segment frame with SA Tourism for long-haul campaigns, so provincial and national spend target the same travellers	SA Tourism

Benchmark precedent

New Zealand gives each priority market a role, such as the USA as its high-yield growth engine, and judges performance on revenue per visitor and length of stay over arrivals (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p53, p55). The required change for the Western Cape is to replace the arrivals KPI with yield-based metrics and build partnerships with specialist distribution networks (p56).

Link forward

Initiative I1, segment-led activation and yield in mature markets, carries this entry with focus area 5 (section 4.3). **Indicators** T1-01 international arrivals and T1-02 arrivals by market group at impact level, and T2-01 segment home-market arrivals at outcome level (section 5.2).

THEME 1.1 · TRAVELLER, BRAND AND PROPOSITION · FOCUS AREA 2

Create green-season demand with MICE and events

The green season is a seat problem and an events problem at once: June holds 6.4% of the year's international seats, while international meetings already cluster in the months leisure travel leaves empty.

Hypothesis and disposition

December 2025. Develop the Seasonality and Spread Proposition (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p64), reprinted from March 2026 as Develop seasonality, spread and Mega events proposition (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p7).

October 2026: Reworded. June holds 6.4% of seats, and ICCA meetings cluster from May to November. Spread moved to focus areas 3 and 10, and business events replaced mega events as the lever. MIDAS's seasonality analysis and the Demand-Side MICE landscape drove the change.

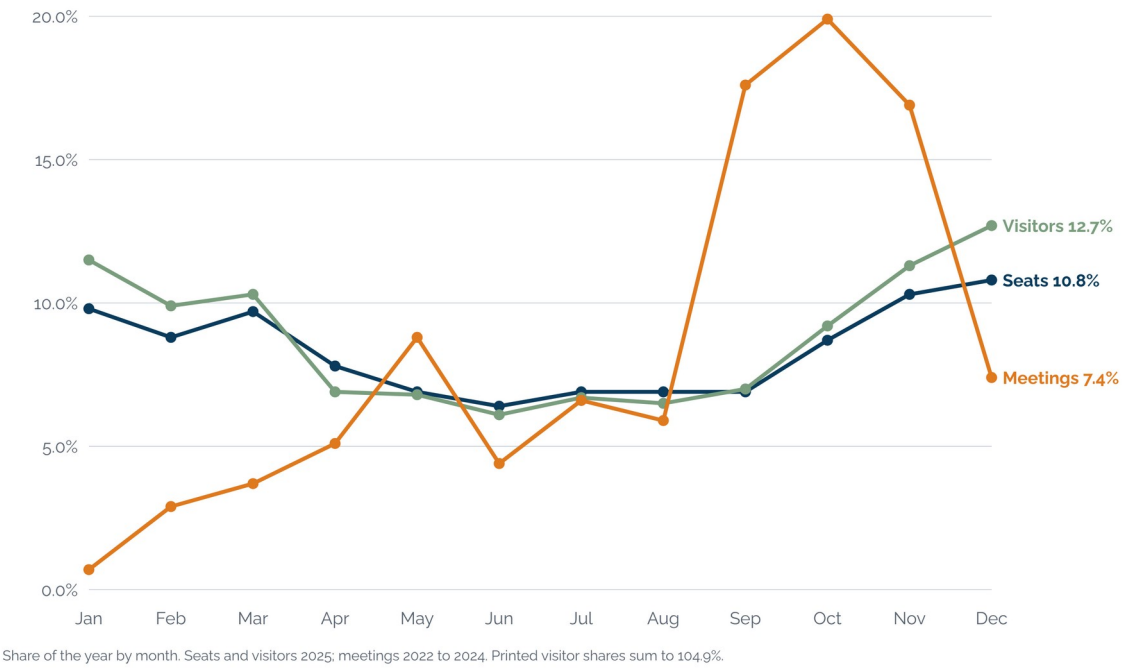
Evidence

Seats and visitors both fall away from April to September. Business events do not.

Table 3.3. Leisure demand and seats trough from May to September, while international meetings peak from September to November.

Finding	Figure	Source
June has the fewest seats	June 6.4% of 2025 international seat capacity at Cape Town International; May to September 6.4% to 6.9% a month; November 10.3% and December 10.8%	MIDAS, Seasonality
Visitors follow the seats	61% of 2024 overseas visitors travelled from October to March and 39% from April to September	Diag p32
Meetings fill the trough	109 of 136 ICCA meetings in Cape Town from 2022 to 2024 fell between May and November; September to November alone held 74	DSA p37
The meetings base is growing	ICCA meetings 33 in 2022, 46 in 2023 and 58 in 2024 (41,571 participants); 37 UIA association meetings in 2025, 58% of South Africa's	DSA p37, p38
Business events lift yield	International business-event delegates spend R6,400 a day; Cape Town hotel occupancy was 53% in June 2023	DSA p34
The venue confirms the gap	June to August and December to January are structurally weak for MICE, and peak-date constraints lose events	SIR p45, p46 (CTICC)

Source: MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026 (scheduled seats); Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025 (Diag; Wesgro Visitor Tracking Survey 2024, while the Market Assessment, p25, prints the same split on a Cape Town overseas air-arrivals basis); Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026 (DSA); Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026 (SIR). The ICCA months are summed from the printed monthly counts. The 2025 ICCA row of 65 covers Stellenbosch and Cape Town and is not comparable.



Share of the year by month. Seats and visitors 2025; meetings 2022 to 2024. Printed visitor shares sum to 104.9%.

Figure 3.1. International meetings peak from September to November, when seats and overseas visitors are still climbing out of the winter trough.

Source: MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, Seasonality (share of 2025 international seat capacity at Cape Town International); Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p12 (month of travel, Western Cape overseas visitors, 2025) and p37 (ICCA meetings in Cape Town by month, 2022 to 2024, shares of 136 computed from the printed counts).

Two limits matter. The baseline the report uses is the printed 61% to 39% split for 2024; the 65% October to March share in earlier project material appears in no deliverable [Summary of Findings, 14 Oct 2026: source of the 65% to confirm]. And only conferences are measured: meetings are absent from provincial statistics, incentive volumes are unverified and exhibitions are unquantified (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p36).

Recommendation

Wesgro should build an April to September events spine and sell it with the seats. The Diagnostic proposed the spine itself, anchored on a small set of flagship weeks, with green-season flight, stay and experience packages sold through airline and trade partners (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p32). The Demand-Side Analysis adds the routes by segment: off-peak conference bids in sectors where the province is strong, cooler-season incentive packages for Indian and Gulf planners, and winter midweek packages for corporate meetings (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p40).

Who acts	Action	Lead and partners
Wesgro	Publish a green-season events calendar and aim Convention Bureau bids at May to September in the province's strongest sectors	Convention Bureau; Destination Marketing
Wesgro	Package green-season flight, stay and experiences with airlines and trade, and test cooler-season incentive packages with Indian and Gulf planners	Air Access; Destination Marketing; airlines
Wesgro	Measure meetings, incentives and exhibitions, which provincial statistics do not cover today	Research; CTICC
Partners	Programme lifestyle events in December and January and keep peak dates for international events; market flower, fynbos and whale events earlier	CTICC; Overberg and West Coast LTOs
Partners	Agree one event acquisition and calendar strategy across Wesgro, the Convention Bureau, the City and the Province	City of Cape Town; DEDAT

Who acts	Action	Lead and partners
National	Ease visas for regional African delegates, whose event demand the venue operator rates as visa-constrained	Home Affairs; SA National Convention Bureau

Benchmark precedent

Victoria curates a portfolio of global, cultural, regional and business events that generate repeat, predictable demand spikes across the year, and Melbourne's monthly arrivals stay between 7% and 12% of the year (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p17, p18). The required change for the Western Cape is a unified event acquisition and calendar strategy across Wesgro, the Convention Bureau, the City and the Province, with a proactive conference bidding pipeline (p20).

Link forward

Initiative I2, green-season events and business-events calendar (section 4.3). **Indicators** T1-05 green-season share at impact level, and T2-02 ICCA meetings and T2-03 May to September seat share at outcome level (section 5.2).

THEME 1.1 · TRAVELLER, BRAND AND PROPOSITION · FOCUS AREA 3

Make the whole province findable and bookable

Outside the Cape Peninsula, the Winelands and the Garden Route, most product cannot be booked where travellers book, so interest the province has already earned has nowhere to land.

Hypothesis and disposition

December 2025. Facilitate Adoption Along the Path to Purchase (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p64).

October 2026: Reworded. Community product is unbookable, CapeNature takes about 70% of its reservations by phone and rural stock has OTA gaps. The focus moved from source-market platforms to the province's own product being invisible and unbookable. The Inclusion Plan, the stakeholder interviews and the Infrastructure Report drove the change.

Evidence

Table 3.4. Bookability holds on the three core routes and falls away on the outer routes and in every shortlisted community.

Finding	Figure	Source
Three of six routes are bookable	Digital and bookability rated Ready on the Cape Peninsula, Garden Route and Cape Winelands routes; Developing on the Whale Coast; Gap on the West Coast and Route 62	IR p30, p40, p51, p62, p73, p84
Rural stock is invisible	Most rural properties have no OTA presence; outer-district stock has near-zero visibility on booking platforms	IR p93, p95
Small operators lack booking	About 40% or more of smaller operators lack online booking, a gap no capital programme addresses	IR p32
No community is bookable	None of 19 profiled communities rates Ready on digital and bookability; 8 rate Developing and 11 Gap	SCIP p20 to p26, p40 to p51
Community product sells by phone	Four Zwelihle guides sell by phone with no shared booking channel; Visit Knysna lists nine township guides as phone contacts	SCIP p34, p47
Large attractions rely on phones	CapeNature takes about 70% of its reservations through its call centre rather than its online platform	SIR p42

Source: Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026 (IR; the ~40% has no printed scope or source); SME and Community Inclusion Plan, Sep 2026 (SCIP; ratings compiled from the community profiles, LTO confirmation outstanding); Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026 (SIR). The 70% is CapeNature's own reservation mix, not a provincial share.

No deliverable counts bookable products. The platform scan planned at inception produced no output (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p15, p17), so the indicator this entry needs most, the share of provincial product listed on OTAs by district, has no baseline yet [bookable-product count by district: Wesgro Research to build; see section 5.4].

Recommendation

Wesgro should treat bookability as infrastructure: count it, close it district by district and then place it on the platforms each market uses. The Inclusion Plan sets a community's first deliverable as one live booking route, published operating dates, a named customer contact and a simple record of bookings and local revenue (SME and Community Inclusion Plan, Sep 2026, p33). Growth markets book on their own platforms: Trip.com and Fliggy in China, MakeMyTrip in India and Almosafer in the Gulf (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p45, p47, p49).

Who acts	Action	Lead and partners
Wesgro	Run a bookability census of provincial product by district and publish it as the baseline	Research; LTOs
Wesgro	Run a digital onboarding drive for small operators and cellars on the West Coast, Route 62 and the Overberg	Tourism; district municipalities
Wesgro	Deepen OTA partnerships with Trip.com, Almosafer and Booking.com, and list packaged regional itineraries on them	Destination Marketing; OTAs
Partners	Give each pilot community one live booking route before any promotion (focus area 13)	LTOs; community sellers
Partners	Move CapeNature reservations online and complete cashless payments at reserve level	CapeNature
National	Extend rural broadband under SA Connect, and lift the national rule that blocks bank-card payments on the George bus	National government

Benchmark precedent

New Zealand packages regional clusters into bookable long-haul itineraries and pairs regional operators with specialist global travel designers (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p55). The transferable lesson the deck draws for the Western Cape is to use Cape Town as a gateway that spreads value across the province through bookable regional experiences (p51).

Link forward

Initiative I3, bookable province programme (section 4.3); the community booking routes run through **I12** (focus area 13). **Indicators** T2-04 share of operators bookable online and T2-05 CapeNature online booking share (section 5.2).

3.1.2 Source market growth and diversification

The second theme is about which markets grow the base. It holds one focus area per market group: India and China, which reach the province through hubs; the mature long-haul markets; and regional Africa. The theme name carries through from December unchanged.

THEME 1.2 · SOURCE MARKET GROWTH AND DIVERSIFICATION · FOCUS AREA 4

Convert India and China hub traffic

About 101,000 Indian and Chinese travellers a year already reach Cape Town through Gulf and African hubs, and with no direct Indian route likely before 2030, converting that flow is the lever available now.

Hypothesis and disposition

December 2025. Pivot to Growth Markets (China, India, ME, ASEAN) (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p64).

October 2026: Reworded. About 101,000 travellers a year already fly in via hubs. The Middle East and ASEAN left the title, and the lever narrowed from pivoting to converting traffic already in the air. The Demand-Side route-to-market work and MIDAS drove the change. The Middle East stays in the growth model's acceleration group.

Evidence

Table 3.5. India and China reach Cape Town only through hubs, and the direct route that would change that is at least five years away.

Finding	Figure	Source
India flies in through hubs	About 71,000 Indian travellers a year reach Cape Town via hubs; Addis Ababa and Dubai carry more than 80% of them	DSA p48; MIDAS, Indian Market
China flies in through hubs	About 30,000 Chinese travellers a year via Dubai, Addis Ababa, Doha and Singapore (MIDAS: 29,600 in 2025)	DSA p46; MIDAS, Chinese Market
No Indian route before 2030	Air India and IndiGo have no aircraft to spare before the end of the decade, and no South African airline can fly the sector	MIDAS, Indian Market; DSA p48
A Chinese route is a state decision	Chinese routes follow government-to-government agreements; Guangzhou is the likely start, with China Southern or China Eastern	MIDAS, Chinese Market
Hub routes have room	Load factor Dubai 72.3%, Addis Ababa 71.9% and Doha 65.2%, year to November 2025; the hub markets add 206,584 arrivals in the base case to 2035	MIDAS, Seasonality; MA p20
Growth is fast from a low base	India 76,547 to 165,260 and China with Hong Kong 43,412 to 92,598, base case, 2025 to 2035	MA p22; DSA p23

Source: Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026 (DSA); MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026 (weighted GDS bookings, twelve months to November 2025); Market Assessment Report, May 2026 (MA, 2025 base). The 101,000 is the sum of the two printed estimates; the hub tables beneath them sum to 97,579 and carry no year.

The accelerated case depends on what this entry cannot deliver alone. Without confirmed direct routes, the Demand-Side Analysis says, volume reverts to base (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p20). The entry therefore works the hub flow now and builds the route case for later.

Recommendation

Wesgro should run India and China as conversion markets through the hubs and as relationship markets for the direct route. MIDAS recommends early relationship-building with Indian carriers and the Indian authorities, and treating China as a long-term investment in which awareness and indirect volume come before any non-stop service (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, Indian and Chinese Market Opportunity). The Demand-Side Analysis adds activation inside Xiaohongshu, Douyin and MakeMyTrip, and trade-led conversion over broad awareness (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p55).

Who acts	Action	Lead and partners
Wesgro	Secure added frequency from Emirates, Qatar Airways and Ethiopian Airlines, with joint market support tied to Indian and Chinese sales	Air Access; hub carriers
Wesgro	Activate inside Xiaohongshu, Douyin and MakeMyTrip with market-specific itineraries and Trip.com packages	Destination Marketing; OTAs; trade
Wesgro	Build long-term route cases for the India and China corridors and keep a standing relationship with Indian carriers, China Southern and China Eastern	Air Access
Partners	Ready the product for both markets: Mandarin and Indian-language guiding, Alipay and WeChat Pay, visible vegetarian options	Product owners; attractions; hospitality bodies
National	Escalate visa processing for China and India, and the route designation for China that is decided government to government	Home Affairs; Department of Transport

Benchmark precedent

Singapore converts transit into visits through its Stopover Programme and Free Singapore Tour, run by the tourism board, Changi Airport Group and Singapore Airlines under one strategy (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p40). New Zealand ties marketing budgets to named long-haul corridors and designs campaigns to support route breakeven, recording more than 16,000 incremental bookings and a return of about NZD 55m in 2023/24 (p54).

Link forward

Initiative I4, India and China hub conversion (section 4.3), with the direct-route cases run under **I6** (focus area 7). **Indicators** T1-02 arrivals by market group at impact level and T2-06 India and China hub arrivals at outcome level (section 5.2).

THEME 1.2 · SOURCE MARKET GROWTH AND DIVERSIFICATION · FOCUS AREA 5

Increase yield in mature markets

The mature markets already pay the most and fill the fullest routes, so growth there comes from more value per visitor and more seats on existing routes, not from more marketing.

Hypothesis and disposition

December 2025. Increase Yield in Mature Markets (UK, Europe, N. America) (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p64).

October 2026: Validated. Full routes. The October title drops the list of markets. MIDAS drove the disposition: the mature long-haul routes run above 80% load, and carriers on full routes raise fares before they add seats.

Evidence

Table 3.6. The highest-spending visitors come from the slowest-growing markets on the fullest routes.

Finding	Figure	Source
Five mature routes are full	Load factor Newark 88.6%, Atlanta 84.3%, Frankfurt 83.0%, Heathrow 83.0% and Washington 80.2%; eleven of the 27 tabled routes run above 80%	MIDAS, Seasonality
Carriers price before they add	Rather than increase capacity, carriers will seek higher selling fares rather than add new services	MIDAS, In Conclusion
Mature visitors spend most	Average spend in the province USA R32,900, UK R26,500 and Germany R25,600, against Zimbabwe R8,500 (2024)	DSA p14
The province earns a premium	13% to 16% of national arrivals by quarter in 2025, but 20% to 27% of national foreign direct spend	DSA p11
Five markets dominate	The top five supplied 63% of overseas arrivals in 2025, and the UK, Germany and USA 52%	DSA p13
Growth is steady	Mature group 587,287 to 766,067 arrivals in the base case, 2025 to 2035	MA p21; DSA p22

Source: MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026 (year to November 2025); Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026 (DSA); Market Assessment Report, May 2026 (MA, 2025 base). No deliverable carries fare, revenue-per-seat or yield data.

The yield lever rests on MIDAS's reading of carrier behaviour, and no deliverable models a yield uplift. The entry therefore sets yield as an indicator to establish, not a target to hit, until spend per visitor by market is tracked every year [yield baseline: SAT spend per visitor by market as an annual series; only 2024 is printed].

Recommendation

Wesgro should protect share and raise value per visitor in the mature markets, and work the full routes for frequency and gauge before it chases new ones. The Demand-Side Analysis frames the job as protecting share, increasing yield and driving regional dispersal while new growth markets are developed (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p17). MIDAS sees tactical room for added frequency on some routes and larger aircraft from some airlines (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, In Conclusion).

Who acts	Action	Lead and partners
Wesgro	Make the case to carriers on the five full routes for added frequency or larger aircraft, backed by green-season marketing	Air Access; airlines
Wesgro	Sell Discerning Connoisseur product through luxury advisors and high-end operators in the UK, USA, Germany, France and Switzerland	Destination Marketing; trade

Who acts	Action	Lead and partners
Wesgro	Add a yield measure, spend per visitor by market with length of stay, beside arrivals in Wesgro's own targets	Research
Partners	Invest in premium product outside the Metro and in the midscale branded accommodation the province lacks (focus areas 11 and 15)	Accommodation investors; hospitality bodies
National	Escalate the cap on US carriers, the unsigned Open Skies agreement and the bilateral agreements that limit airlift	Department of Transport

Benchmark precedent

New Zealand runs yield-based performance, putting revenue per visitor and length of stay ahead of arrivals growth and selling premium regional itineraries through specialist travel designers (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p55). Its total visitor spend grew 9.2% in the year to March 2025, against arrivals growth of 5.9% (p53).

Link forward

Initiative I1, segment-led activation and yield in mature markets (section 4.3), with the frequency case run under **I6** (focus area 7). **Indicators** T1-03 direct foreign spend at impact level and T2-07 mature-market spend per visitor at outcome level (section 5.2).

THEME 1.2 · SOURCE MARKET GROWTH AND DIVERSIFICATION · FOCUS AREA 6

Build a regional foundation (Africa)

Regional Africa is the province's steadiest volume and its least developed premium market: Zimbabwe and Namibia supply 62% of African arrivals, while Nigerian and Ghanaian visitors spend R31,000 and R27,700 each.

Hypothesis and disposition

December 2025. Build a Regional Foundation (Africa) (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p64).

October 2026: Validated. Regional routes are full, and Nigerian and Ghanaian visitors spend R31,000 and R27,700 each. The Demand-Side African opportunity section, the Skift African memo and MIDAS's regional route loads drove the disposition.

Evidence

Table 3.7. African demand is a Southern African volume base with two high-spending West African markets and regional routes above 80% load.

Finding	Figure	Source
A Southern African base	323,971 African arrivals across 16 markets in 2024; Zimbabwe and Namibia supplied 62%	DSA p27
Two high-spend markets	Spend per visitor Nigeria R31,000, Ghana R27,700 and Kenya R16,900; African visitors spent R4.2bn in 2025	DSA p29, p30
Regional routes are full	Luanda 86.2% and 83.4%, Maputo 83.3%, Gaborone 82.3%, Mauritius 81.8% and Harare 81.3%; MIDAS names all five markets for added capacity	MIDAS, Seasonality
The pool is large	Nigeria 310,000 to 510,000 and Kenya 240,000 to 400,000 addressable adult trips a year; Ghana 55,000 to 100,000	Skift African, s3
South Africa is considered	10.9% consideration share among Nigerian and 13.4% among Kenyan outbound travellers, second only to Dubai in Kenya	Skift African, s4.2, s4.3
Regional growth is steady	Regional group 292,514 to 402,812 arrivals in the base case, 2025 to 2035, with Kenya the strongest upside	MA p23; DSA p24

Source: Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026 (DSA; SA Tourism 2024 Departure Survey and 2025 performance report); MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026 (year to November 2025); Skift African Market Analysis, 16 Mar 2026 (working analysis, by section); Market Assessment Report, May 2026 (MA). The printed spend averages do not reproduce from the totals and visitor counts on the same slide; the report quotes the printed averages.

Three cautions apply. Nigeria and Ghana have no row in the growth model, so no 2035 arrivals figure exists for the two highest-spending African markets [Nigeria and Ghana arrivals targets: not modelled; Wesgro Research to add both]. The Skift memo places Ghana in its watch tier for brand seeding rather than conversion (Skift African Market Analysis, 16 Mar 2026, s5). And regional travellers tend to stop in Johannesburg rather than continue to Cape Town (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p35).

Recommendation

Wesgro should run Africa as two markets: a regional volume base held through capacity and value, and a premium growth market in Nigeria and Kenya won through conversion. Skift makes Nigeria the priority for luxury, status-driven and conference travel and Kenya the priority for business mobility and premium urban breaks, both through premium activation and the trade (Skift African Market Analysis, 16 Mar 2026, s5).

Regional demand also helps the green season, because trips are shorter in lead time and easier to convert (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p31).

Who acts	Action	Lead and partners
Wesgro	Make the capacity case on the five full regional routes with Airlink, Ethiopian Airlines, Kenya Airways and the other regional carriers	Air Access; airlines
Wesgro	Run premium, trade-led activation in Nigeria and Kenya for leisure, weddings and conferences with leisure extensions	Destination Marketing; Convention Bureau; trade
Wesgro	Add Nigeria and Ghana to the growth model and commission consumer research for Botswana, Zambia, Ghana and Rwanda	Research
Partners	Convert rest-of-Africa travellers who stop in Johannesburg with onward packages, and give regional delegates leisure extensions	Cape Town Tourism; CTICC; tour operators; Cross-Border Road Transport Agency
National	Escalate visas for African markets, building on the 2024 Ghana visa waiver, and liberalisation of regional air routes	Home Affairs; Department of Transport

Benchmark precedent

Kenya draws 41% of its arrivals from Africa, mainly Uganda and Tanzania, and positions Nairobi as East Africa's aviation, diplomatic and business hub through Kenya Airways' regional network (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p32, p34). The transferable changes the deck draws for the Western Cape are to treat MICE as a system lever and to align city, provincial and national actors around one gateway strategy (p35).

Link forward

Initiative I5, regional Africa programme (section 4.3), with the regional capacity case run under **I6** (focus area 7). **Indicators** T1-02 arrivals by market group at impact level and T2-08 African arrivals and spend at outcome level (section 5.2).

3.2 Pillar 2: Transform supply

Supply sets the ceiling on the growth case. The airport caps arrivals before its relief arrives, and outside the Metro the product exists but is hard to reach, book or stay in.

The December tree asked the pillar to remove mobility, infrastructure and product constraints so as to expand the province's physical carrying capacity (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p64). The evidence confirmed the objective and located each constraint.

- **The gateway.** Current air access caps inbound seats at 1.8 million, and the base case passes that ceiling at the 2030 year point (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p21). New terminal space at Cape Town International is due about 2032 and the runway about 2033 (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p103).
- **The regions.** Accessibility scores fall from 4.7 in the Cape Metro to 1.0 in the Central Karoo, and one touring route of six is rated Ready (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p88 to p90, p29).
- **The product.** The constraint is less about creating new attractions and more about turning existing assets into complete, accessible visitor experiences (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p114).

Two structural changes happened in this pillar. The December entry on air access and cruise split in two, because MIDAS gave air access its own evidence base. The Infrastructure Report found cruise to be a product and marketing lever, with Cape Town's berth at about 40% of its season capacity (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p110). The entry on infrastructure, visa and safety deficits moved to Pillar 3 because its levers sit nationally (section 3.3.2).

The Infrastructure Report reads transport as a connectivity and dispersal challenge, not a province-wide capacity crisis, with Cape Town International the key gateway risk (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p114). Pillar 2 follows that reading: one capacity entry at the gateway and five entries about reach, product and experience.

Table 3.8. Pillar 2 holds six focus areas: the air entry was reworded, cruise is new and the four others carried through as Validated.

Focus area	Disposition	What the evidence showed	Initiative
7 Win direct routes and add seats on full routes	Reworded	Eleven of 27 routes run above 80% load, fares rise before seats, and runway relief lands about 2033	I6
8 Grow cruise calls and ports	New	Cape Town's berth runs at about 40% of season capacity; growth comes through product and marketing	I7
9 Accelerate tourism-enabling internal mobility	Validated	Accessibility falls from 4.7 in the Metro to 1.0 in the Central Karoo	I8
10 Support diversified route and product development	Validated	Assets outside the Metro are not turned into product, and one route of six is Ready	I9
11 Align visitor experience in-destination	Validated	No mid-scale branded tier sits between luxury estates and basic self-catering	I10
12 Balance impact on nature-based attractions	Validated	Boulders is near carrying capacity and Cableway queues reach three hours	I11

Source: Chapter 3 entries 7 to 12. Dispositions as recorded at the 14 October 2026 review [Summary of Findings, 14 Oct 2026, pp15 to 16: deck page reference to be confirmed].

3.2.1 Accessibility, connectivity and infrastructure

The first supply theme covers how visitors reach the province and move through it. It holds three focus areas: air access, cruise and internal mobility. The December entry on visa and safety deficits left this theme for section 3.3.2.

THEME 2.1 · ACCESSIBILITY, CONNECTIVITY AND INFRASTRUCTURE · FOCUS AREA 7

Win direct routes and add seats on full routes

Eleven of 27 international routes run above 80% load and carriers raise fares before seats, so the province must win frequency and larger aircraft now, ahead of runway relief in about 2033.

Hypothesis and disposition

December 2025. Close the Air Access and Cruise Capacity Gaps (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p64). The air half of the entry became this focus area and the cruise half became focus area 8.

October 2026: Reworded. The October record gives the reason as 16 of 27 routes above 80% and fares before seats. MIDAS, the source, prints eleven routes above 80%; sixteen is the count at 75% or more, and the report uses both on that basis [Summary of Findings, 14 Oct 2026: the deck's basis for 16 to confirm]. MIDAS and the Infrastructure Report's air-access section drove the change.

Evidence

Table 3.9. The network is full on its best routes, the airport is full at its runway, and relief lands after the base case passes the seat ceiling.

Finding	Figure	Source
Routes are full	11 of 27 tabled routes above 80% load and 16 at 75% or more; network load 76.0%	MIDAS, Seasonality
Fares before seats	Carriers on full routes will seek higher fares rather than add services, though there is tactical room for added frequency and larger aircraft	MIDAS, In Conclusion
A record to build on	17 mainline international routes added from 2015 to 2025, ahead of Santiago (14), Valencia (12) and Calgary (8)	MIDAS, International Comparisons
A seat ceiling in 2030	Current air access caps inbound seats at 1.8 million; the base case passes it at the 2030 year point (1,802,929)	DSA p21
Relief lands late	The single runway caps movements at about 30 an hour; ACSA's ~R11.3bn programme brings the international terminal about 2032 and the runway about 2033	IR p102, p103
Second gateways	George is solved by 2028 (R310m, to about 2m passengers); Cape Winelands is an upside bet with no firm named carrier	IR p104 to p109

Source: MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026 (twelve months to November 2025; 76.0% is the printed network total and the 27 rows sum to 75.0%); Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026 (DSA); Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026 (IR).

The Infrastructure Report puts the timing problem in one line: the certain fix is the latest, and the earliest big-capacity option is the least certain (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p109). No airline took part in the first phase of stakeholder engagement, so the carriers' own view of frequency and gauge is still to be tested (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p16).

Recommendation

Wesgro should split the air agenda by horizon. Until about 2032 the job is to fill and enlarge what already flies: frequency and larger aircraft on the full routes, hub-carrier capacity and the five regional routes MIDAS names. After that, the job is to have direct India and China route cases ready when runway capacity arrives. The Demand-Side Analysis lists the moves: added frequency from Emirates, Qatar Airways and Ethiopian Airlines, long-term route cases for India and China, and coordinated airline incentives through Cape Town Air Access (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p54).

Who acts	Action	Lead and partners
Wesgro	Run a seat-retention and frequency programme on the full routes, with joint marketing tied to route performance	Air Access; Destination Marketing; airlines
Wesgro	Set up a public-private air access fund for route support, on the Chilean model	Air Access; DEDAT; City of Cape Town; private sector
Wesgro	Treat runway delivery as the first risk: track approvals and milestones quarterly and commission a capacity-against-demand model to 2035	Air Access; Research
Partners	Deliver the runway, terminals and George upgrade on the published dates; close the funding and name a carrier at Cape Winelands	ACSA; Cape Winelands Airport
National	Escalate bilateral air service agreements, the cap on US carriers and immigration processing at Cape Town International	Department of Transport; Home Affairs

Benchmark precedent

Chile treated its gateway airport as economic infrastructure: a private concession funded a ~US$900 million expansion at Santiago, and international seats grew ~40% to 50% between 2013 and 2019 under open-skies agreements (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p23, p25, p26). The required change for the Western Cape is a permanent, well-funded public-private air access fund and active lobbying for air service liberalisation (p28).

Link forward

Initiative I6, route development and seat retention with a public-private air access fund (section 4.3).
Indicators T1-01 international arrivals at impact level, and T2-09 seats and routes and T2-10 routes above 80% load at outcome level (section 5.2).

THEME 2.1 · ACCESSIBILITY, CONNECTIVITY AND INFRASTRUCTURE · FOCUS AREA 8

Grow cruise calls and ports

Cruise already brings about R1.79bn a year with Cape Town's berth at about 40% of its season capacity, so growth comes from ships, excursions and regional day stops, not from port capital.

Hypothesis and disposition

December 2025. Close the Air Access and Cruise Capacity Gaps (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p64), the cruise half of the entry.

October 2026: New. The October record gives 79 calls in 2024/25 and a plan to 250. The Infrastructure Report's cruise and ports section drove the split from air access: cruise runs well below berth capacity and is a product and marketing lever, a different problem from the airport.

Evidence

Table 3.10. Cape Town's berth has room, ship size and wind are the constraints, and port capital is going to freight.

Finding	Figure	Source
Calls and passengers	79 vessels and 127,178 passengers in 2024/25, up from 67 vessels in 2023/24	Diag p37
A berth with room	Cape Town's equipped berth ran at about 40% of a season capacity of 150 or more calls; 83 calls and R1.79bn economic impact in 2024/25	IR p110
Ship size and wind bind	300m maximum ship length at the equipped berth; the South-Easter delays berthing; no shore power	IR p110
Regional ports extend the route	Mossel Bay 21 calls and about 13,000 passengers, with a R22m reception facility opened in November 2025; Saldanha Bay 3 trial calls into an ore terminal	IR p111
Port capital is for freight	Cape Town's container expansion and Saldanha's R4bn iron-ore expansion add no cruise capacity; the R22m Mossel Bay facility is the only cruise capital	IR p112
Packaging works	Mossel Bay calls rose from four before COVID to 27 a season through closer coordination and better excursion packaging, with Wesgro credited	SIR p20, p21

Source: Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025 (Diag; Western Cape Cruise Liner Industry Economic Contribution 2024/25 Season, cited through the Diagnostic); Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026 (IR); Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026 (SIR). The Diagnostic counts 79 vessels and the Infrastructure Report 83 calls for the same season; passengers and economic impact agree. Mossel Bay's 27 a season is its own figure; the Infrastructure Report prints 21.

The plan to 250 calls in the October record appears in no deliverable. Cape Town's season capacity is about 150 calls, so 250 would need a second berth, a longer season or the regional ports counted in, and no document describes any of these [plan to 250 cruise calls: source, horizon and definition to confirm with Cruise Cape Town]. The report carries the 2024/25 baseline and holds the target open until the source is in hand.

Recommendation

Wesgro should grow cruise through ships, excursions and regional day stops. The Infrastructure Report's own conclusion is to grow it through product and marketing, not capital works (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p112). Cape Town anchors the itinerary, and Mossel Bay and Saldanha Bay extend it west and east as day stops rather than home ports (p111). The Inception Report names home porting and expedition vessels as the segments that bring longer stays and higher local spend (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p9).

Who acts	Action	Lead and partners
Wesgro	Market Cape Town to lines whose ships fit the 300m berth and to expedition and home-porting operators, with pre- and post-cruise stays	Cruise Cape Town; Destination Marketing
Wesgro	Back Mossel Bay now with packaged excursions and line marketing; keep Saldanha Bay on watch until demand is proven	Cruise Cape Town; Mossel Bay municipality
Wesgro	Put community and regional product on cruise-operator channels, starting with a bookable walk in the Knysna townships	Cruise Cape Town; LTOs
Partners	Manage berth scheduling and wind delays at Cape Town, plan for shore power and review the 300m limit	Transnet National Ports Authority; V&A Waterfront
National	Put cruise into port planning, since current Western Cape port capital carries no cruise capacity	Transnet

Benchmark precedent

The Benchmarking Report has no cruise case, and its final screening replaced the cruise criterion used at inception with ease of access and visas (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p11; Inception Report, Nov 2025, p30). The nearest analogue is Singapore's stopover programme, in which the tourism board, the airport and the airline share one strategy to turn transit passengers into visitors (p40).

Link forward

Initiative I7, cruise growth through product (section 4.3). **Indicator** T2-11 cruise calls and passengers at outcome level, with the target held open until the 250-call plan is sourced (section 5.2).

THEME 2.1 · ACCESSIBILITY, CONNECTIVITY AND INFRASTRUCTURE · FOCUS AREA 9

Accelerate tourism-enabling internal mobility

Accessibility falls from 4.7 out of 5 in the Cape Metro to 1.0 in the Central Karoo, and beyond the Metro and the Garden Route the province is effectively car-only.

Hypothesis and disposition

December 2025. Accelerate Tourism-Enabling Internal Mobility (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p64).

October 2026: Validated. Access decays from 4.7 to 1.0. The Infrastructure Report's comparative regional analysis and the Department of Mobility's evidence to the stakeholder programme drove the disposition. The 4.7 is the Metro's score on attractions and services; on transport it scores 5.0.

Evidence

Table 3.11. Access falls away with distance from Cape Town, and the rail and road assets that exist are not run for visitors.

Finding	Figure	Source
Access decays with distance	Accessibility Cape Metro 4.7 (5.0 on transport), Cape Winelands 3.3, Garden Route 3.0, Overberg 2.0, West Coast 1.7, Central Karoo 1.0	IR p88 to p90
One corridor, mostly car-only	The N2 is the only continuous inter-regional tourism corridor; beyond the Metro and the Garden Route the province is effectively car-only	IR p98, p99
Rail exists but not for visitors	Metrorail runs 104 of 121 stations and 22.7m trips (FY2025), but no rail reaches the airport and the Southern Line's visitor branding dates to 2007	IR p100
The Metro's last mile is unfunded	MyCiTi Phase 2 (R3.3bn) does not reach Chapman's Peak, Constantia or Cape Point south	IR p32
No shuttles between towns	No inter-town shuttle on the Garden Route despite obvious demand; no public tourism transport between Hermanus, Stanford, Elim and Agulhas	IR p90, p67
Stakeholders rank it high	18 insight rows from 8 of 16 organisations, 10 rated High, including public transport and airport transfer times	SIR p22, p20 to p46

Source: Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026 (IR; comparative regional analysis on a 1 to 5 scale); Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026 (SIR; the theme count is reconstructed from the appendix tables, which print no tally).

The Infrastructure Report's conclusion frames the entry: transport is primarily a connectivity and dispersal challenge, not a province-wide capacity crisis (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p114). The Department of Mobility adds that mobility responsibilities are split across three tiers of government (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p23).

Recommendation

Wesgro should not try to build transport. It should make the transport that exists usable for visitors and aggregate the demand that makes shuttles viable. The Southern Line is a ready-made, low-cost scenic corridor through Muizenberg, Kalk Bay, Boulders and Simon's Town (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p100). On the West Coast, operators say a shared shuttle needs demand aggregation and booking integration to work (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p41).

Who acts	Action	Lead and partners
Wesgro	Package the Southern Line as a visitor product, with refreshed branding and day passes	Tourism; Destination Marketing; City of Cape Town; PRASA
Wesgro	Aggregate demand and bookings for corridor shuttles, starting on the Garden Route and between Cape Town, Darling and the West Coast	Tourism; district municipalities; private operators
Wesgro	Sell the transfer inside the itinerary on the N2 and R62 routes, so visitors without a car can buy the trip	Destination Marketing; operators
Partners	Complete the Central Line recovery, MyCiTi Phase 2 and the unfunded last mile to Cape Point, with integrated ticketing	City of Cape Town; PRASA; Department of Mobility
Partners	Take forward the Cape Town to George rapid rail assessment and extend the George public transport model	Department of Mobility
National	Lift the national rule that blocks bank-card payments on the George bus, and fund passenger rail beyond the Metro	National government; PRASA

Benchmark precedent

No benchmark case carries an internal mobility lever with figures. The nearest is Chile, where a domestic air network links Santiago to Patagonia, Atacama, Valparaíso and the wine valleys, run as a designed portfolio rather than standalone attractions (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p25, p27).

Link forward

Initiative I8, corridor mobility (section 4.3). **Indicators** T1-06 share of arrivals and spend outside the Metro at impact level, and T2-12 accessibility score by district and T2-13 corridor transfer products at outcome level (section 5.2).

3.2.2 Product and destination capacity

The second supply theme covers what visitors find once they arrive: product beyond the icons, the quality of the stay and the limits of the flagship sites. All three December entries carried through as Validated.

THEME 2.2 · PRODUCT AND DESTINATION CAPACITY · FOCUS AREA 10

Support diversified route and product development

The province does not lack attractions; it lacks finished experiences around them, with assets outside the Metro left without guides, interpretation or bookable product and one touring route of six rated Ready.

Hypothesis and disposition

December 2025. Support Diversified Route and Product Development (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p64).

October 2026: Validated. Idle assets and cold zones. The Infrastructure Report's spatial maps and route scorecards drove the disposition, and 11 of the 16 organisations in the stakeholder programme raised the theme. Cold zones is the report's own term; idle assets paraphrases its finding that assets are inactivated or underused.

Evidence

Table 3.12. Assets are spread across the province, but product, packaging and investment stop at the core routes.

Finding	Figure	Source
Assets are spread	50,332 mapped tourism assets; the Cape Metro holds 40.3% and the five other districts the rest	IR p2, p23
Assets are not activated	Overberg and West Coast marine and wildflower assets have no guided tours, interpretation centres or bookable product; the Central Karoo and northern inland are attraction deserts	IR p93
Cold zones in every district	Industrial belts with zero tourism conversion in the Metro; the inland Garden Route north of the N2; the Rûens interior; the N1 transit corridor in the Central Karoo	IR p24, p35, p68, p79
One route is Ready	Cape Peninsula Ready; Garden Route, Cape Winelands, Whale Coast and Route 62 Developing; West Coast and Cederberg Emerging	IR p29, p39, p50, p61, p72, p83
No capital for product	Non-wine diversification in the Winelands is strategy, not committed capital; De Hoop lacks accommodation investment; Overberg year-round product is unfunded	IR p54, p76
Stakeholders see concentration	11 of 16 organisations raised the theme; the offer is seen as concentrated around Cape Town and a narrow set of icons	SIR p11

Source: Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026 (IR; route ratings are approximate and the asset count carries no year); Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026 (SIR; organisation count reconstructed from the appendix tables).

The Infrastructure Report's own conclusion is that the constraint is less about creating new attractions and more about turning existing assets into complete, accessible visitor experiences (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p114). No deliverable counts the assets that have no product around them [assets with no bookable product or guided access, by district: needs the Wesgro supply database behind the 50,332 count].

Recommendation

Wesgro should deepen the three corridors closest to ready, the Garden Route, the Cape Winelands and the Overberg, and package the two outer routes as slow-travel products. The Infrastructure Report places the strongest regional opportunity in deepening existing corridors through connectivity, packaging and service depth (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p114). Dispersal needs deliberate corridor investment, not organic spillover from Cape Town (p5). Stellenbosch and George can anchor regional business events (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p41).

Who acts	Action	Lead and partners
Wesgro	Package bookable multi-day itineraries on each of the six touring routes, starting with the Whale Coast east of Hermanus, Route 62 and the West Coast	Tourism; Destination Marketing; LTOs
Wesgro	Activate cold-zone assets with guided tours, interpretation and bookable product, beginning with the marine and wildflower assets	Tourism; CapeNature; SANParks; LTOs
Wesgro	Build regional conference offers in Stellenbosch and George, with stays before and after Cape Town events	Convention Bureau
Partners	Invest in accommodation and service depth beyond Hermanus, in Route 62's secondary towns and beyond Langebaan and Paternoster (focus area 15)	Accommodation investors; municipalities
Partners	Refresh flagship product: Robben Island beyond the prison tour; the Cableway's lower station	Robben Island Museum; Table Mountain Aerial Cableway
National	Complete SA Connect rural broadband and SANParks precinct projects such as the R81.7m Agulhas lighthouse precinct	National government; SANParks

Benchmark precedent

Chile ran Santiago, Valparaíso, the wine valleys and Patagonia as one portfolio, which raised global awareness, earned revenue in the shoulder season and lengthened stays as visitors explored several regions (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p27). The required change for the Western Cape is to sell experiences as curated journeys and move from asset marketing to experience-led packaging (p28).

Link forward

Initiative I9, corridor product development (section 4.3). **Indicators** T1-06 share of arrivals and spend outside the Metro at impact level and T2-14 readiness by district at outcome level (section 5.2).

THEME 2.2 · PRODUCT AND DESTINATION CAPACITY · FOCUS AREA 11

Align visitor experience in-destination

The province offers luxury estates and basic self-catering with no mid-scale branded tier between them, and service, interpretation and language readiness thin out with distance from Cape Town.

Hypothesis and disposition

December 2025. Align Visitor Experience In-Destination (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p64).

October 2026: Validated. Mid-scale gap. The Infrastructure Report's accommodation mapping, the stakeholder evidence on service quality and the Valencia and Singapore benchmarks drove the disposition. The gap is stated in words; no deliverable counts mid-scale rooms.

Evidence

Table 3.13. The experience breaks at the middle of the accommodation market, at the service counter and at the arrival gate.

Finding	Figure	Source
No mid-scale tier	Province-wide, no midscale branded product sits between luxury estates and basic self-catering; mid-market stock is effectively absent outside Stellenbosch	IR p95, p47
Accommodation range thins	Accommodation range Ready on three routes, Developing on the Whale Coast and Route 62, and Gap on the West Coast	IR p30, p40, p51, p62, p73, p84
A two-tier system	Strong product sits where visitors cannot easily reach or afford it; accommodation readiness 4.7 in the Metro against 2.0 in the Central Karoo	IR p89
Service is uneven	Mossel Bay calls restaurant quality and service a major weakness; CapeNature is wary of scaling international demand because service readiness is uneven	SIR p20, p43
Growth markets need adapting	Limited Mandarin-language services; little visibility of vegetarian options or Indian-language guides; no Arabic-language booking or local-currency options	DSA p51
The arrival is the weak point	The international airport is the most negative node in Cape Town's online mentions; immigration processing and peak-hour throughput need work	Diag p22; DSA p54

Source: Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026 (IR); Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026 (SIR); Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026 (DSA); Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025 (Diag; Mentionlytics sentiment data).

Two measures are missing. No deliverable counts mid-scale rooms or beds [mid-scale room count by district: needs the Wesgro supply database or an accommodation audit], and none prints a visitor satisfaction score. The only accommodation figure in hand is a demand share: 3.6% of 2024 visitors stayed in hotels, against 17.4% in self-catering (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p27).

Recommendation

Wesgro should lead a province-wide quality and standards framework and make the investment case for mid-scale accommodation in secondary nodes. The Benchmarking Report assigns the framework to Wesgro in so many words: a province-wide quality and standards framework that aligns all tourism stakeholders under consistent benchmarks led by Wesgro (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p42). Valencia shows the form: a provincial quality charter, phased by district, with certification visible on booking platforms (p49).

Who acts	Action	Lead and partners
Wesgro	Set up a provincial quality charter, phased by district, with certification visible on booking platforms and support for SMMEs to comply	Tourism; DEDAT; industry bodies
Wesgro	Prepare for growth markets: multilingual guiding, digital payments and culturally relevant product for Chinese, Indian and Gulf visitors	Tourism; Destination Marketing
Wesgro	Make the investment case for mid-scale and conference-capable hotels in George and Mossel Bay, east of Hermanus and on Route 62 (focus area 15)	Tourism; private investors
Partners	Close service and interpretation gaps at named sites: Robben Island interpretation, CapeNature service readiness, restaurant quality in Mossel Bay	Attraction operators; municipalities; CATHSSETA
National	Improve immigration processing and peak-hour throughput at Cape Town International, and deliver the terminal relief due about 2032	Home Affairs; ACSA

Benchmark precedent

Singapore's tourism board used a hotel industry transformation map, a hotel rejuvenation fund and the Hotels Act to move the destination from short stopovers toward longer stays and higher spend (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p41). Valencia's Qualitur programme and SICTED quality system raised service consistency, reputation and repeat visitation (p47).

Link forward

Initiative I10, visitor experience and quality standards (section 4.3). **Indicator** T2-15 routes rated Ready at outcome level (section 5.2).

THEME 2.2 · PRODUCT AND DESTINATION CAPACITY · FOCUS AREA 12

Balance impact on nature-based attractions

Boulders is near carrying capacity and Cableway queues reach three hours, so growth at the flagship nature sites must come from managing flows and steering visitors to under-marketed reserves.

Hypothesis and disposition

December 2025. Balance Impact on Nature-Based Attractions (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p64).

October 2026: Validated. Flagship limits. The stakeholder evidence on Boulders and Table Mountain and the Infrastructure Report's record of flagship congestion drove the disposition. The operators and the province state the limits; no deliverable prints a visitor cap or carrying-capacity figure for any flagship site.

Evidence

Table 3.14. The flagship sites are at or near their limits, the overflow reserves are under-marketed and climate is already closing sites.

Finding	Figure	Source
Boulders is near capacity	Some nature-based attractions, Boulders among them, are already near carrying capacity, so more volume there is undesirable (Department of Economic Development)	SIR p24
The summit cannot grow	Environmental restrictions limit permanent expansion on Table Mountain's summit; peak queues run up to three hours up and two hours down	SIR p36; IR p28
Overflow is under-marketed	Peak-season congestion at flagship sites while overflow reserves remain under-marketed	IR p88
Tourism funds conservation	CapeNature's ecotourism income pays for alien clearing, fire response and species protection, and public funding alone will not suffice	SIR p43, p44
Climate already bites	Flooding, fire and heat are closing CapeNature sites; weather cancellations cost Robben Island roughly R16m a year	SIR p43, p33
Seasonal windows are narrow	Whale season peaks from September to November; climate change threatens the predictability of the wildflower season	IR p67, p64

Source: Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026 (SIR; insight statements by organisation, not quotations); Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026 (IR).

No deliverable prints annual visitors or permitted capacity for Table Mountain, Boulders, Robben Island, Cape Point or Kirstenbosch [flagship visitor counts and capacity: request from SANParks, the Cableway, Robben Island Museum and SANBI]. The only printed daily cap in hand is the City's permit system at the Witzands dunes near Atlantis, which is 80% pre-booked online (SME and Community Inclusion Plan, Sep 2026, p41).

Recommendation

Wesgro should stop marketing volume to the flagship sites and use them as the hook that sends visitors elsewhere. The Department of Economic Development wants further growth directed to under-visited parts of the province rather than constrained flagships (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p24). The Peninsula route's own opportunities are to disperse visitors beyond the highest-volume attractions and to expand shoulder-season experiences (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p30). The site operators hold the flow tools, from digital flow management to tiered pricing (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p3; Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p44).

Who acts	Action	Lead and partners
Wesgro	Market the under-used reserves, and the Southern Line to Boulders and Simon's Town, as alternatives to peak-hour flagship visits	Destination Marketing; CapeNature; PRASA
Wesgro	Request visitor counts and capacity for the five flagship sites and publish them as the baseline	Research; site operators
Wesgro	Report spend per visitor and length of stay for nature product alongside visitor numbers	Research
Partners	Introduce digital visitor-flow management at the Cableway, Boulders and Cape Point, and tiered pricing where mandates allow	Table Mountain Aerial Cableway; SANParks; CapeNature
Partners	Make reserve product climate-resilient by reassessing asset formats and siting	CapeNature
National	Agree a visitor management plan for Table Mountain National Park and Boulders with the City and the operators	SANParks

Benchmark precedent

Kenya treats conservation as national economic infrastructure, with tourism-funded conservation financing and community conservancies that sustain demand and environmental integrity (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p33). New Zealand uses land-use controls and premium curation on the principle that capacity discipline protects long-term pricing power (p55).

Link forward

Initiative I11, flagship site demand management (section 4.3). **Indicator** T2-16 peak queue at the Cableway at outcome level, with flagship visitor counts added once the baseline is in hand (section 5.2).

Execution plan

Monitoring and evaluation framework

Appendices